Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Revelation

Revelation 1:1

- The word revelation (Greek apokalupsis) introduces the book's visionary style as apocalyptic writing (see Revelation Book Introduction, "Apocalyptic Writing"). God shares his message through mysterious symbols, numbers, and word pictures.
- of Jesus Christ: He is both the source and the main subject of the book.
- what must soon come to pass: Compare Revelation 3:11; 22:6–7; Luke 18:8; Romans 16:20.

Revelation 1:1–11

Revelation begins with a three-part introduction, including:

1. a prologue (Revelation 1:1–3),
2. a letter introduction (Revelation 1:4–8), and
3. a historical introduction (Revelation 1:9–11).

Revelation 1:2

testifies ... testimony: The Greek words behind these terms are martureō (meaning "to bear witness") and marturia (meaning "witness" or "testimony"). These related Greek words refer to a true and reliable witness. They highlight that the sacrificial witness of Jesus and the true testimony of John form the foundation for the revelation.

Revelation 1:3

- blessed is the one: Revelation includes seven promises of blessing (Revelation 1:3; 14:13; 16:15; 19:9; 20:6; 22:7, 14).
- hear and obey: True listening means you follow what you hear.

Revelation 1:4

- To the seven churches do not mean there were only seven churches in the Roman province of Asia. Instead, these seven churches represent the entire group. "Grace and peace" is a typical Christian greeting (see study notes on 2 Corinthians 1:1–2; 2 Thessalonians 1:1–2). The order of these words is consistent in the New Testament, suggesting that peace follows from God's grace.
- from Him who is and was and is to come: God controlled the past, will control the future, and has complete authority and power over every present crisis (see also Revelation 1:8; 4:8; 11:17; 16:5).
- the seven spirits: Some argue that the "seven spirits" are seven angels, but the phrase fits between references to God the Father (Revelation 1:4) and God the Son (1:5), making this passage a description of the Trinity (see Matthew 28:19; John 14:26; 15:26; 2 Corinthians 13:14; 1 Peter 1:2). The number seven acknowledges the holy spirit's perfection (compare Zechariah 4:2, 6, 10).

Revelation 1:4–8

The second introduction (see study note on Revelation 1:1–11) follows the style of a Greek letter.

Revelation 1:5

- Jesus serves as our example for sharing the good of salvation (Revelation 1:2).
- The belief that Jesus was the first to rise from the dead is essential to Christian faith (1 Corinthians 15:14, 17).
- As the ruler of all the kings of the world (see also Revelation 17:14; 19:16), he is the ultimate Lord of everything. People in the Roman world were expected to declare Caesar as the absolute lord; many early Christians died for their belief that Jesus alone holds that position.

Revelation 1:5–6

- In this doxology, John explains why we should praise Jesus.
- A doxology is a short statement that gives praise to God or to Jesus. These statements often end with the word Amen (see Romans 11:36; Philippians 4:20), which expresses agreement and affirmation.

Revelation 1:8

I am is the name of God in the Old Testament (Exodus 3:13–14; 6:2; Deuteronomy 6:4). Jesus used this name for himself (compare John 4:26). Alpha and Omega are the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet. They show that God's actions cover everything. God is completely in control.

Revelation 1:9

- your brother and partner: Although separated from other Christians due to imprisonment, John felt a sense of community with them in suffering. This connection was based on hope in God's kingdom and a willingness to endure.
- The Roman fortress on the island of Patmos held prisoners and exiles. Patmos was part of a group of islands that protected the busy seaport of Miletus.

- because of the word of God and my testimony: These two statements mean the same thing. This is a common pattern in Semitic writing, where the second line repeats or explains the first. By John's time, Jews were convincing Roman authorities that Christianity was different from Judaism and therefore not an authorized religion.

Revelation 1:9–11

This third introduction (see study note on Revelation 1:1–11) is historical. It shows God speaking to people through real events. While in exile, God gave John an important mission.

Revelation 1:10

- the Lord's day: In the Roman world, this term referred to celebrations for Caesar. Christians, however, used it for their weekly worship, celebrating the resurrection of Jesus. The earliest Christians worshiped in Jewish synagogues on the Sabbath, the last day of the week (Acts 18:4). By the time of Revelation, they were no longer allowed in synagogues and gathered on the first day of the week, which marked the resurrection (see study note on Luke 24:1; see also Acts 20:7).
- The loud voice like a trumpet blast announced the Lord's coming.

Revelation 1:11

Write ... and send: God appointed John as a prophet and messenger of his revelation (see Revelation 22:8, 10; compare Isaiah 6:8–9; Jeremiah 2:1–2; Ezekiel 2:1–3; 34:1–2).

Revelation 1:12

- I turned to see the voice that was speaking: This refers to the loud voice in Revelation 1:10.
- seven gold lampstands: The lighted menorah was a symbol of God's presence among his people (Exodus 27:21; Leviticus 24:1–4) and his all-seeing eyes in the world (Zechariah 4:10).

Revelation 1:12–20

John's first vision shows Christ as a wise, strong, and powerful messenger of God who always cares for his people.

Revelation 1:13

- the Son of Man (or a son of man): Son of Man is a title Jesus used for himself (see Daniel 7:13; Matthew 8:20; 9:6; 16:13; Mark 2:28; 9:9; 14:41; John 1:51; 3:13; 5:27).
- The long robe and gold sash give Christ an authoritative look (see Revelation 19:13–16; Daniel 10:5). The robe was a priestly garment symbolizing purity and holiness.

Revelation 1:14

- White hair symbolizes wisdom and maturity. This image reflects Daniel's vision of the Ancient One (Daniel 7:9).
- His eyes, like flames of fire, see through deception. The one who knows everything will judge everyone (see Daniel 10:6; Hebrews 4:13).

Revelation 1:15

- Refined or hardened bronze feet suggest stability, firmness, and security (compare Daniel 10:6).
- The thundering voice shows God's power. When God speaks, people will listen (compare Ezekiel 43:2).

Revelation 1:16

- The seven stars symbolize the complete church. The church is safe in the right hand of the Son of Man, which means it is under his care, acceptance, and blessing.
- The sharp sword coming from his mouth represents his powerful message and judgment (see Revelation 19:15; Genesis 3:24; Ephesians 6:17; Hebrews 4:12). Jesus announces both grace and judgment, but here the focus is on his role in carrying out judgment (see Revelation 2:12, 16; 19:15, 21; compare Isaiah 11:4).

Revelation 1:17

- When I saw Him, I fell ... dead: Terror and fainting, if not death itself (see Exodus 33:20), often occur when someone sees God (see Isaiah 6:1–5; Matthew 28:4). The Lord kindly responds by touching with his right hand (compare Matthew 25:34) and saying, Do not be afraid (compare Luke 1:13), showing both grace and acceptance.
- I am: This phrase identifies Jesus as God (see study note on Revelation 1:8).

Revelation 1:18

- the Living One: The Son of Man (Revelation:13) has defeated death, so he holds the keys to death and controls the outcome of our greatest fear (see Revelation 20:14; Hebrews 2:14–15). Jesus has full authority to offer hope in a hostile world.
- Hades: See study note on Revelation 6:7–8.

Revelation 1:19

Write: In the vision, God instructs John on what to do for him (see Isaiah 6:9–10). This vision aims to help the church understand the present and future from God's viewpoint (Revelation 1:20).

Revelation 1:20

- John must record what he sees because Revelation is an important message for the churches.
- The angels (or messengers; Greek angelos) of the seven churches could be:

1. the guardian angels of these churches (compare Matthew 18:10; Acts 12:15);
2. the leading officials of the churches (compare Matthew 11:10, where "messenger" is angelos); or
3. a personification of the ethos (spirit or character) of the church.

The best understanding is probably a combination of 1 and 3.

Revelation 2:1

- To the angel ... write: This repeated command introducing each of the seven letters shows the message's importance.
- Ephesus became the main city of the Roman province of Asia. It had the temple of Artemis (see Acts 19:23–35) and became the richest banking center in that region. The people of Ephesus were very independent. They refused help from Alexander to rebuild their temple after its destruction in the 300s BC. They argued that one god should not build a temple for another god (see Strabo, Geography 14.1.22). The pride of the Ephesians also led to the uproar against Paul (Acts 19:23–41).

Revelation 2:1–7

The letter to the church in Ephesus speaks to Christians who follow traditions. They are faithful but have lost their early, strong love for Christ and each other (see Revelation 2:5).

Revelation 2:1–3.22

The seven messages to the seven churches show the condition of Christ's church when Revelation was written, and it is similar today. God still calls Christians to be faithful and honest. Those who listen to Christ's message will receive God's promised rewards. Those who do not will face judgment.

Revelation 2:2–3

- I know: This repeated refrain (Revelation 2:9, 13, 19; 3:1, 8, 15) shows Christ knows everything about his people, their actions, and their situations.
- The Ephesian Christians had a correct understanding of their beliefs, marked by perseverance and faithfulness. They examined various claims, disciplined evil people, could tell what is true and false, and patiently suffered for their faith in Christ.

Revelation 2:4

You have abandoned your first love: When the church began, their love for Christ and each other was strong. Struggles with false teachers and persecution caused that original love to grow cold. Correct beliefs, action, and even suffering (Revelation 2:2–3) are only an empty form of Christian life if living and active love is missing (1 Corinthians 13).

Revelation 2:5

Christ calls those who keep the faith to return to him and repent of being cold-hearted. The warning, I will come and remove your lampstand, means they would lose their status as a church. God would treat them like he did the people who abandoned their faith within Israel (see Romans 11).

Revelation 2:6

Little is known about the Nicolaitans. Their teachings (Revelation 2:15) suggest they ate food offered to idols and engaged in sexual immorality. The council in Jerusalem prohibited this behavior (see Acts 15:20, 29). The early church father Irenaeus, writing around AD 180, said that the Nicolaitans followed the teaching of Nicolas (Acts 6:3–5). He believed John's writings opposed the Nicolaitan false teachings linked to Cerinthus (see 1 John Book Introduction, "Setting").

Revelation 2:7

Obeying leads to the reward of eternal life, symbolized by fruit from the tree of life (Revelation 22:2; Genesis 3:22).

Revelation 2:8

The seaport village of Smyrna was destroyed and rebuilt many times. Like Christ, the city was once dead but is now alive. It is the only one of the seven cities that still exists today as Izmir in modern Turkey.

Revelation 2:8–11

The letter to the church in Smyrna describes suffering Christians under intense pressures who need a mes-

sage of assurance. Smyrna represents a small church that stays faithful to God despite difficult times.

Revelation 2:9

- Jesus linked material poverty with the blessing of being rich in God's Kingdom (Matthew 5:3, 10–12; Luke 6:20).
- Jews without faith are criticized for siding with Satan against Christianity (Revelation 3:9; see John 8:44; Acts 14:2–5; 17:13; 18:6; 20:3; Galatians 5:11; 1 Thessalonians 2:14–16). At the Jewish council of Jamnia, Jewish leaders decided that Christians were unholy and should be excluded. John was not speaking against Jewish people as a whole. He was a Jew describing the actions of some of his fellow Jews toward both Jewish and non-Jewish Christians.

Revelation 2:10

- John saw the devil as the source of human hostility against Christians.
- The period of their suffering would last ten days, symbolizing a limited time of persecution (see 1 Peter 1:6). If they remained faithful, their reward would be the crown of eternal life.
- even unto death: John's student Polycarp became a martyr in Smyrna in the mid-100s AD.

Revelation 2:11

Staying faithful until death is seen as a victory. Overcoming the second death means gaining eternal life (see Revelation 20:5–6, 14; 21:8).

Revelation 2:12

Christ's sharp, double-edged sword shows that these Christians would face the Lord's harshest judgment (see Revelation 2:16; see study note on Revelation 1:16). The double-edged sword was a Roman symbol of authority, representing Pergamum as the province's capital. If the church failed, Christ, the true governor of the city, would use his authority against them.

Revelation 2:12–17

The letter to the church in Pergamum describes Christians facing temptations to compromise their morals and loyalty to God. Pergamum was the first capital of the Roman province of Asia. The city had a famous library, and its people developed the use of animal skins for writing.

Revelation 2:13

- The throne of Satan might refer to the altar of Zeus on the mountain above the city or to emperor worship at the temple of Augustus. For many years, the Roman governor had his throne there, and the great temple of Athena and other shrines were also in Pergamum. Calling it Satan's city might also refer to the temple of Asclepius, whose symbol was coiled snakes. The city was dedicated to the Roman gods and emperor worship.
- Antipas is otherwise unknown.

Revelation 2:14–15

- Some people in Pergamum mixed Christianity with pagan beliefs and took part in immoral activities. John compares them to Balaam, who led Israel into sin (see Numbers 25:1–3; 2 Peter 2:15; Jude 1:11).
- Nicolaitans: see study note on Revelation 2:6.

Revelation 2:17

- Those who stay faithful to Christ will receive manna, which is nourishment from heaven (see Exodus 16:11–36).
- hidden manna: During the exodus, people placed a jar of manna in the ark of the covenant (Exodus 16:33–36). Jewish tradition said that when the Messiah (God's chosen one) comes, the ark will reappear, and people will eat manna at the messianic banquet. Jesus is the bread from heaven and the bread of life (John 6:32–35; compare Exodus 16:4–21).
- A white stone was often given to winners in athletic competitions, and people commonly used a white stone for admission to special banquets or festivities. It suggests acceptance and victory.
- The new name probably refers to the recipient's transformed nature in Christ (see Genesis 17:5; 32:28; John 1:42).

Revelation 2:18

- Thyatira was an outpost city known for its many trade guilds, including weavers and dyers (Acts 16:14).
- The flaming eyes of the Son of God show deep perception. The solid feet represent Christ's stability, contrasting with the famous Colossus of Rhodes. This enormous statue was once thought to be stable until an earthquake destroyed it in 226 BC.

Revelation 2:18–29

The letter to the church in Thyatira warns Christians against combining their faith with pagan practices and worldly behaviors.

Revelation 2:19

Christ praises the Thyatirans for their knowledge and understanding of everything.

Revelation 2:20–21

The mention of Jezebel, who led Israel into idol worship and immoral behavior (1 Kings 16:31–33; 21:5–26), highlights a serious issue. Like the Old Testament queen who led the worship of Baal (see 1 Kings 16:31; 18:4; 19:1–3), this unknown Jezebel claimed to be a prophet but was leading God's people into immorality. This included sexual misconduct and forming idolatrous alliances and actions (Exodus 34:15–16; Psalm 106:39; Isaiah 57:7–8).

Revelation 2:21

Through messengers like John, Christ gave this false prophet a chance to repent for her wrong teachings and actions. However, like many others, she refused (compare Revelation 9:20–21).

Revelation 2:22–23

- Christ's judgment on this "Jezebel" and on those who follow her takes place in three stages:

1. Jezebel will suffer on a sickbed;
2. her followers will experience great suffering; and
3. her children will die (compare Acts 5:5, 10; 1 Corinthians 11:30).

This judgment is similar to the plagues on Egypt, which ended with the deaths of Egypt's firstborn sons (see Exodus 12:29–30).

- God knows people's thoughts and intentions (see Jeremiah 17:10; Acts 1:24; Hebrews 4:12–13). He gives each person the judgment that person deserves (see Revelation 22:12; Jeremiah 17:10; Matthew 16:27).

Revelation 2:24

The phrase deep things of Satan might refer to the Gnostic god Bythos (which means "Depth"). In some Gnostic writings, Bythos is the source of other spiritual beings. His partner Sigē (which means "Silence") completes this divine pair. Gnostic groups often taught that people could reach salvation through secret knowledge.

Revelation 2:26–28

- Christ promises that those who obey will share authority with him. This is symbolized by the iron rod that will break the opposition like clay pots (quoting Psalm 2:8–9; compare Revelation 12:5; 19:15).
- The morning star is the planet Venus, which signals the coming of a new day. Here, it refers to the promise of resurrection when Christ returns (Revelation 22:16; 2 Peter 1:19).

Revelation 3:1

- Sardis was about 80 kilometers (50 miles) east of Smyrna on the southeast highway from Pergamum and Thyatira. It was home to a large community of wealthy Jews. They were called "Sephardic" because this name came from an ancient name for the city. The city also had a strong, fortified acropolis, which often gave its people too much confidence in their own safety.
- Other churches may have thought the Christians in Sardis were active and strong. However, their focus on worldly life showed that they lacked true spiritual life.

Revelation 3:1–6

The letter to the church in Sardis warns Christians who seem spiritually alive but are actually dead. Without true change, they will face God's judgment.

Revelation 3:2–3

- The church in Sardis needed to wake up and pay attention. If they did not, they would face sudden judgment. The city of Sardis had experienced this kind of surprise attack twice. The first happened when the forces of Cyrus entered the city through a secret tunnel around 549 or 546 BC. The second happened in 189 BC when Antiochus III attacked the city in the same way.

In both cases, the watchmen were not alert, and the city fell. The same would happen to the Christians there if they did not meet God's requirements (see Revelation 20:12; Ephesians 2:10; James 2:20).

- like a thief: Like the invaders in the city's history, Christ would come suddenly (see Revelation 16:15; Matthew 24:43; 1 Thessalonians 5:2; 2 Peter 3:10).

Revelation 3:4

- Soiled ... garments symbolize an impure life (Zechariah 3:4), while white clothes represent purity (see Revelation 6:11; 7:13–14; 22:14).
- How they walk means how a person lives (see Genesis 17:1; Psalms 81:13; 82:5; Romans 8:4; Galatians 5:16).

Revelation 3:5

Having one's name in the Book of Life (see Revelation 20:12–15; Daniel 7:10) means assurance of God's

acceptance and eternal life (see Revelation 17:8; 20:12; Philippians 4:3; see also Luke 10:20). If God erases a name, it implies condemnation and eternal death (see Exodus 32:32–33; Psalm 69:28).

Revelation 3:7

- Philadelphia was located in the foothills of the Timolus Mountains, with fertile plains to the east. The city often suffered from severe earthquakes, which left it weak and poor.
- This verse uses phrases from Isaiah 22:22.
- key of David: Jesus the Messiah, God's chosen one, is the successor to David's royal line. As the gatekeeper of heaven, Jesus has the authority to open and close the way to heaven (compare Matthew 16:19).

Revelation 3:7–13

The letter to the church in Philadelphia encourages Christians who feel weak and powerless to understand that their true strength is in Christ. This comforting message includes no words of disapproval. The kingdom of God relies not on human strength or wisdom but on God's power and authority.

Revelation 3:8

- I know: See study note on Revelation 2:2–3.
- little strength: Like the city of Philadelphia itself (see study note on Revelation 3:7), the Christians there were not wealthy and lacked status and power. However, Christ opened a door for them (see Revelation 3:7) to claim his status and authority. Despite their weakness, the Philadelphia church obeyed Christ's word and did not deny him under pressure.

Revelation 3:9

- those who belong to the synagogue of Satan: The Christians in Philadelphia experienced mistreatment from Jews who opposed Christianity (see study note on Revelation 2:9).
- bow down at your feet: In ancient times, captives often had to bow before their conquerors (see Isaiah 49:23; 60:14). The church's human enemies will eventually recognize that God loves Christians.

Revelation 3:10

- Jesus will protect Christians who persevere and remain faithful during difficult times (compare Isaiah 43:2–4; John 10:27–28; 1 Corinthians 10:13; Hebrews 6:18–19).
- The hour of testing refers to the end times when the world experiences severe difficulties.

Revelation 3:11

Christians must remain faithful. They need to persevere through difficulties to keep their crown, which is their expected reward.

Revelation 3:12

- Victorious Christians are secure in God's household, like pillars, and they will never have to leave it.
- The name of God inscribed on them shows God's ownership and the security Christians enjoy (see Revelation 7:4; 14:1).
- The new Jerusalem is not built by humans. Instead, it is God's gift from heaven (Revelation 21:2–10).
- A new name was a sign of God's blessing (see also Revelation 2:17). Abram, Jacob, Simon, and others received new names (Genesis 17:5; 32:28; John 1:42).

Revelation 3:14

- Laodicea was located 65 kilometers (40 miles) southeast of Philadelphia. It was the economic and judicial center of a region that included Colossae and Hierapolis. The people of Laodicea were proud of their independence. After a severe earthquake in AD 60, Laodicea refused help from Rome and rebuilt their city on their own, making it very beautiful (Tacitus, Annals 14.27).
- Amen: Used as an oath, "Amen" is a promise of truth (Isaiah 65:16). Jesus represents the truth (John 8:32; 14:6), and his message is confirmed by the truthfulness and reliability of his word.
- The description of Christ as the faithful and true witness shows that he knew them as they truly were. Although they were wealthy and proud of their status and achievements, they did not meet God's expectations.

Revelation 3:14–22

The letter to the church in Laodicea warns Christians who are lukewarm, meaning they are not fully committed to Christ. Their inconsistent lives show loyalty only to themselves. Their behavior is so displeasing to Christ that he is ready to reject them, as if spitting them out of his mouth.

Revelation 3:15–16

neither cold nor hot: The hot springs in Hierapolis were famous for their healing qualities. Colossae was equally famous for its cold, refreshing springs. In contrast, the water in Laodicea was smelly and lukewarm.

Such water is unpleasant. Jesus was saying that the church's indecisive commitment to him was revolting.

Revelation 3:17

Christians in Laodicea believed they were prosperous and self-sufficient (see study note on Revelation 3:14). However, Jesus saw their true spiritual state as wretched, miserable, and poor.

Revelation 3:18

- Jesus advised the people of Laodicea to change their attitude from self-reliance to relying on God.
- buy from Me gold: They could buy anything they wanted, but they needed heavenly treasures for spiritual riches through faith in Christ.
- refined by fire: Material wealth will not survive God's cleansing by fire (compare 1 Corinthians 3:12–15), but spiritual wealth lasts forever.
- White garments are a symbol of spiritual purity. Laodicea was famous for its black wool cloth, a source of their wealth, which likely represents their proud and unredeemed spiritual state.
- Laodicea's wealth also came from its famous Phrygian eye ointment, possibly used in a local eye clinic linked to the renowned physician Demosthenes Philalethes. The Laodiceans needed to obtain ointment from Christ through faith. Only his eye salve would help them see their sins and repent.

Revelation 3:19

Christ will correct and guide those he loves instead of rejecting them (Proverbs 3:11–12; Hebrews 12:5–6). He remains faithful even to those who are unfaithful (2 Timothy 2:13).

Revelation 3:20

- A person or a church must listen for Jesus knocking and open the door to him. Christ offers a way for a church to revive when it has become spiritually weak and lost connection with him. Simply opening the door can renew their previous bond.
- dine with him, and he with Me: A shared meal represents acceptance, deep friendship, and a covenant relationship (Revelation 19:9; see Genesis 18:1–5, 16–19; Exodus 12:1–31; 18:12; Matthew 26:26–30).

Revelation 3:21

The reward for faith that is victorious and obedient is to sit with Christ on his throne. This picture shows great honor and closeness to Christ. It means that believers will share in his authority when he rules over the new creation.

This reward does **not** mean that Christians become divine. Only God is divine. Instead, Christians share in Christ's victory and in the work he gives them in his kingdom (Revelation 20:4, 6; 22:5; Colossians 3:1–4; 2 Timothy 2:12).

Revelation 4:1

- After this I ... saw: This introductory phrase does not show the order of events (see also Revelation 7:9; 15:5; 18:1; compare 19:1). Instead, it signals a new vision that John receives.
- Come up here: The Lord's voice invites John to see what will happen from God's point of view.

Revelation 4:1–11

The description of God's throne room is beyond what people can easily imagine. It continues the visions in Isaiah 6:1–4, Ezekiel 1:4–28, and Daniel 7:9–10, where God is seen on a powerful and majestic throne. God's throne is a central theme in Revelation. The worship that appears throughout the rest of the book begins from this scene. God's greatness, grace, and glory form the foundation of the church's worship.

Revelation 4:1–5.14

This section introduces upcoming visions and judgments. John presents God in his heavenly court, which is the setting for the drama of Revelation (Revelation 4:1–11). The Lamb also plays a central role (Revelation 5:1–14). John contrasts God's majesty with the supposed majesty of Caesar. God's power and splendor surpass any earthly ruler's ceremonial court.

Revelation 4:2

By being in the Spirit, John could experience spiritual realities (see Revelation 1:10; 17:3; 21:10; Ezekiel 11:1). He could understand insights about God's presence, the heavenly realm, and God's plans in history.

Revelation 4:3

Instead of creating a visual image of God (Exodus 20:4; Deuteronomy 4:15–19), John uses gemstones and the rainbow (Genesis 9:8–17; Ezekiel 1:28) to suggest God's qualities. The rainbow represents God's grace, reminding us of God's promise to Noah (Genesis 9:13–17) that he would never again flood the earth. However, in Revelation, the earth is destroyed by fire (Genesis 19:24–29).

Revelation 4:4

The twenty-four elders on their thrones likely represent all of God's people. They may correspond to the

twelve tribes of the old covenant and the twelve apostles of the new (see Revelation 21:12–14). Some people associate them with the twenty-four divisions of the Israelite priesthood (1 Chronicles 24:1–19).

In this vision, the elders speak and worship in an antiphonal way, which means that two groups take turns speaking or singing.

Revelation 4:5

- The thunder that follows flashes of lightning is a call from God to pay attention (see Revelation 8:5; 11:19; 16:18).
- Before the throne burned seven torches of fire: In ancient times, people placed torches before rulers to show their authority. These torches with burning flames represent the perfect spirit of God.

Revelation 4:6

- a sea of glass, as clear as crystal: The most noticeable part of ancient theaters was the bright mosaic floor where the orchestra performed. This design helped people see the scene clearly (compare Revelation 15:2–4).
- The four living beings represent all of creation.
- covered with eyes: This phrase likely means they had knowledge or understanding. In the ancient world, figures were often covered with a feature to highlight a quality (for example, statues of Artemis were covered with breasts to emphasize fertility). Compare Ezekiel 1:18.

Revelation 4:7

These four creatures symbolize different types of beings:

- a lion represents wild animals,
- an ox represents domesticated animals,
- a human represents humanity, and
- an eagle represents birds (see Ezekiel 1:10).

These figures come from Ezekiel 1 (cherubim) and Isaiah 6 (seraphim). They likely represent the best of creation as worshiping God. Missing from this group of created beings are fish. Ancient people often connected fish with the dangerous or evil sea (see Revelation 21:1). Insects are also missing. In Revelation, insects are linked to locusts that belong to the evil kingdom (see Revelation 9:1–11).

Revelation 4:8

- Day and night: The four beings continuously praised God's main qualities:
- his holiness,
- his power (the Almighty), and
- his eternity (see study note on Revelation 1:4).
- Holy, holy, holy comes from Isaiah 6:3 and is the highest form of worship in Scripture. Repeating something two times shows strong emphasis. Repeating it three times shows the highest level of emphasis.

Revelation 4:9–11

- The twenty-four elders, who speak in an antiphonal chorus (two groups taking turns), give a divine perspective on creation.
- One seated on the throne: This shows a common Jewish practice of not speaking God's name directly.

Revelation 4:11

- Worthy are You: This phrase is never used for God in the Old Testament. However, people in Rome often used it when they worshiped the emperor. In Revelation, it is clear that only God deserves worship.
- You created all things: Many people in the ancient world believed their gods were too busy to care about humans. But God is Almighty in a real and active way. He created all things and continues to rule as Creator and Lord. In Revelation, creation shows that God is in complete control of the world (see Revelation 3:14; 10:6; 14:7; 21:1).
- by Your will they exist and were created: God had a purpose for everything he made.

Revelation 5:1

- The scroll, like a dramatic script, describes God's plan for the world (Psalm 139:16).
- The right hand represents God's gracious authority and power (see Revelation 1:17, 20).
- The writing on both sides of the scroll shows that God's plans for history are full and complete.
- sealed with seven seals: God has placed his purposes for history in something that cannot be opened by human effort (Isaiah 29:11–12; Daniel 8:26). His purposes will be fulfilled only when the seals are broken (see Revelation 5:4).

Revelation 5:1–14

John introduces the Lamb, Jesus Christ, who is the main figure in Revelation and God's chosen one to fulfill his plans.

Revelation 5:2–3

At first, no one in the entire universe seemed to have the divine authority or power to answer the angel's call.

Revelation 5:4

John cried because he feared he would not learn about God's plan for history, even though it was promised to him (Revelation 4:1; see 10:4). His tears show how important the revelation was to him.

Revelation 5:5

- Titles for Jesus such as the Lion ... of Judah (see Genesis 49:9–10) and the Root of David (see Isaiah 11:10), are Old Testament metaphors for the Messiah (see Jeremiah 23:5; 30:9; John 7:42).
- Because Jesus won the victory at the cross (John 16:33), he is the only one worthy to open the scroll and reveal God's purposes (Revelation 4:11; 5:2, 12). God's plan for history centers around Jesus and his actions. His connection to the scroll shows his control of history.

Revelation 5:6

- The Jews expected the Messiah, God's chosen one, to appear as a powerful lion. Instead, Jesus came as a lamb (John 1:29, 36; Acts 8:32–35; 1 Corinthians 5:7; 1 Peter 1:19). The lamb, once slaughtered but now standing, symbolizes the death and resurrection of Jesus.
- The Lamb's seven horns are a symbol of his complete power, and the seven eyes are a symbol of his complete knowledge (see Zechariah 4:10). He is also fully connected to the perfect spirit of God (Revelation 1:4).

Revelation 5:8

- fell down before the Lamb: The crucified and risen Christ has the divine authority to start the events of this age. He is fully worthy of worship.
- The prayers of God's people play a significant role in the judgments and plagues (Revelation 6:9–11; 8:2–5).

Revelation 5:9–10

- The entire created order sings a new song of praise to the lamb (compare Revelation 14:1–5; Psalm 149:1; Isaiah 42:10).
- The lamb is worthy because his sacrifice earned him the right to open the scroll's seals and carry out God's plans in history.
- The song highlights the meaning of the good news about Jesus (1 Peter 1:18–25).

Revelation 5:10

Describing God's people as a kingdom of priests who will achieve ultimate victory and reign with Christ reflects Jesus as both king (Romans 1:3) and high priest (Hebrews 6:20).

Revelation 5:11–12

A massive angelic choir, with thousands and millions of voices, responds in turn. All of heaven answers creation's acknowledgment of Christ's sacrifice.

Revelation 5:12

This doxology (a short statement of praise) gives Jesus divine honors, which are usually only for God (see Revelation 4:11; 5:13; 7:12).

Revelation 5:13

The second antiphonal response echoes from every creature, including those under the earth (the place of the dead) and in the sea (often linked with evil). This may suggest that even those rebelling against God must respond (Isaiah 45:23–25; Romans 14:11; Philippians 2:10–11).

Revelation 5:14

The dramatic introduction of the lamb (Revelation 5:1–14) ends with the living beings (4:6–9). Their Amen affirms the truth of John's vision, while the twenty-four elders bow in worship.

Revelation 6:1–8

The four horses and their riders (see Zechariah 1:8–11; 6:1–8) represent the world's power structures. Their actions lead mainly to war, violence, economic imbalance, and death. Because of this, it is useless to place our hope in these human systems of power.

Revelation 6:1–8.1

The Lamb breaks the seven seals to reveal the significance of history from God's point of view.

Revelation 6:1–16.21

Three sets of seven judgments (the seals, trumpets, and bowls) are central to Revelation. Some believe these judgments happen in a sequence, one after another, totaling twenty-one judgments.

However, it is more likely that the relationship is cyclical, similar to other Jewish apocalyptic writings

(compare Daniel 2, 7, 8, 11). Each set of judgments becomes more intense and adds new details about God's judgment on those who rebel against him. In this view, all three cycles end at the same time, with the return of Christ.

Revelation 6:2

- Some people think the rider on a white horse is Christ, like in Revelation 19:11. But the only similarity between these two images is the horse. The four riders represent a destructive and senseless world. It has no redeeming qualities.
- A bow is a weapon made of a curved piece of wood and a string. People shoot arrows with it. The bow was a common Greco-Roman military equipment. Here it is as a symbol of war.
- to overcome and conquer: The repeated use of the Greek word nikaō (which means "conquer") shows this rider is powerful. The focus on war and conquest shows the deep sinfulness of humanity.

Revelation 6:3–4

The red horse symbolizes bloody violence on earth. The Roman Empire promised peace (the pax Romana), but widespread violence was the grim reality. This rider represents slaughter, including civil unrest and ethnic cleansing.

Revelation 6:5–6

The black horse represents economic and social trouble. The rider carries scales, which were used in ancient commerce, to show this problem. The vision shows extreme inflation. A worker would have to spend a full day's wages to buy one loaf of wheat bread or three loaves of barley. But the prices of luxury items, such as oil and wine, would stay the same. This is a picture of severe social and economic imbalance.

Revelation 6:7–8

- When the fourth seal is opened, a terrifying horse appears. In the ancient world, a pale green color was used to show the color of a dead body.
- Hades: In Greek thought, Hades was the underworld for spirits without bodies. The Hebrew concept of Sheol, the place of the dead (1 Samuel 28:15), was similar.
- The death of one-fourth of the people on earth shows that the final judgment has not yet come (contrast Revelation 6:16–17).
- This set of four woes (sword, famine, disease, and wild animals; compare Ezekiel 14:21) summarizes the hardships of life on earth. The world cannot provide hope for humanity.

Revelation 6:9

Instead of following the destructive ways of the world, the martyrs (those who died for their faith) chose to give their lives because they remained faithful to the word of God.

Revelation 6:9–11

In contrast to the world's destructive ways (Revelation 6:1–8), the fifth seal introduces Christian martyrs who ask how God intends to deal with evil.

Revelation 6:10

- The martyrs called out to God because they trusted his power to address their grievances.
- How long: Is God slow to act? Will justice be served? God acts decisively (see Revelation 6:12–14). His wrath (Revelation 6:16–17) should be understood as justice, fairness, and righteousness (see Exodus 34:5–7; Nehemiah 9:17; Psalms 103:8; 145:8; Joel 2:13; Jonah 4:2; Romans 2:6–11).
- avenge our blood: This plea for God's justice follows the pattern of psalms calling for vengeance (see Psalms 6:3; 74:10; 79:5; 80:4; 137:1–9). It also reflects the covenant curses of Deuteronomy 28:53–57; 32:35 (quoted in Romans 12:19).

Revelation 6:11

- A white robe symbolizes the victory of the martyrs and God's complete acceptance.
- told to rest: Death is a state of rest (compare John 11:11–12) where martyrs await God's justice.
- the full number: Only God knows how many Christians will be killed because of their faith before the end. In his complete authority and power, God will achieve his purposes through his martyred children and will vindicate them at the right time.
- brothers: The Greek word adelphoi refers to both male and female members of the same family.

Revelation 6:12–14

These violent and world-shaking signs are linked in Scripture to the day of the Lord. On this day, God's judgment will disrupt the entire created order (see Isaiah 13:4–12; 34:1–4; Joel 2:1–32; Zephaniah 2:1–3; Mark 13:1–37).

Revelation 6:12–17

The opening of the sixth seal provides a preview of the end of the world.

Revelation 6:15–17

- every slave and free man hid: When God's judgment comes, people who are not redeemed will be terrified. They will try to hide in a safe place, but they will not succeed (Isaiah 2:19–21; Ezekiel 38:20; Hosea 10:8; Luke 23:30). The prophets often warned that this great day would bring wrath and judgment (Isaiah 13:6–11; Joel 1:15; Amos 5:18; Zephaniah 1:14–15).
- The key question about God's judgment is, who can survive? (Malachi 3:2). God's children will be happy to see him (Revelation 5:13–14; 14:3–5) because they understand God's answer to the martyrs' call for justice (6:9–11), and they have nothing to fear from God's judgment (Acts 10:34–36; Romans 5:1–2). Those who have harmed God's people will tremble in fear as they face the wrath of the Lamb.

Revelation 7:1–3

- Do not ... until: God commands the four angels to hold back the winds for a short time. They must not harm the earth, the sea, or the trees until the servants of God receive his seal on their foreheads.
- The seal of the living God signifies belonging to God's family; God owns and protects his people (2 Corinthians 1:22; Ephesians 1:13–14). In ancient times, sealing or tattooing showed ownership.
- The angel carrying the seal identified God's people, answering who would survive God's wrath (Revelation 6:17; see Ezekiel 9:3–8; John 17:14–15) and furthering the promise of protection (Revelation 3:10; see also 11:1–2).

Revelation 7:1–8

The first vision in the interlude shows how God protects his faithful followers from any ultimate harm.

Revelation 7:1–17

Three interludes occur in Revelation 6–14 (Revelation 7; 10:1–11:14; 12:1–14:20). These interludes explain the place of God's holy people and help readers understand the scenes that came before them. In this first interlude, which appears before the seventh seal is opened, two visions show how God protects his people and confirms his calling on them.

Revelation 7:4–8

Who are the 144,000? This list of the tribes of Israel does not match the twelve physical tribes exactly. Instead, it shows that God knows exactly who belongs to him. By the 90s AD, Israel's twelve tribes no longer existed. Ten tribes were scattered when Assyria conquered the northern kingdom of Israel (2 Kings 17:1–41).

The early Christian church saw itself symbolically as the Israel of God (Matthew 19:28; Romans 2:28–29; 9:6–8; Galatians 3:29; 6:16; Philippians 3:3). The 144,000 likely represent all faithful Christians (compare Revelation 14:1–5; 21:12–17).

The list starts with Judah, the royal tribe of Jesus, but replaces Dan with Manasseh, one of Joseph's two tribes. The tribe of Dan fell into idolatry (Judges 18:14–31; 1 Kings 12:25–30), and early Christians saw it as the symbol of evil.

Revelation 7:9

- This large group of believers (Revelation 7:14) is too numerous to count, fulfilling God's promises to Abraham (Genesis 15:5; 17:4–5; Romans 4:16–24; Galatians 3:29).
- White robes (Revelation 6:11) and palm branches (John 12:13) are ancient symbols of victory and success. They add to the celebration that happens after God ends the hostile world.

Revelation 7:9–17

The second vision in the interlude shows heaven filled with a crowd so large that no one can count it. They rejoice because they are safe in Christ, and all their tears and sorrows have ended.

Revelation 7:10

In ancient times, victory parades celebrated conquerors with loud chants. The shout of Salvation means "victory" or "deliverance." It honors God's triumph and prepares readers for his rule.

Revelation 7:11–12

The angels, elders, and four living beings all bowed before God. They responded together with a sevenfold doxology (complete praise) to honor God's eternal nature. The word Amen comes before and after the doxology, serving as a strong affirmation of God's victory.

Revelation 7:14

- who have come out of: See Revelation 6:9; 20:4.
- the great tribulation: A period of terrible and distressing events (see Revelation 1:9; 2:9–10; Deuteronomy 4:30–31; Matthew 24:21–22; Acts 14:22).
- they have washed their robes ... in the blood of the Lamb: This description is a symbol of Christ's redeeming death for them.

- made them white: This phrase shows their victory over sin and death and their acceptance by God into eternal life.

Revelation 7:15

- serve Him day and night: Serving God is a constant duty for Christians.
- God's temple represents his presence (also see Revelation 11:19; compare 21:22).

Revelation 7:16–17

- For those living in deserts, water and shade from the sun feel like paradise (see also Revelation 21:6; 22:1, 17; Psalm 23:1–2; Ezekiel 47:1–12; John 7:37–38).
- in the center of the throne: The Lamb is closely connected with God.
- Christ's role as the shepherd of God's people (compare Psalm 23; Matthew 15:24; John 10:3, 11, 14; Hebrews 13:20; 1 Peter 2:25) means he protects and provides for the sheep, bringing hope and salvation to his people (see Ezekiel 34:11–16, 23–24).

Revelation 8:1

- The opening of the seventh seal ends the first act and starts a dramatic silence. This silence suggests the mystery of God's actions in the world (Revelation 10:4; 1 Kings 19:11–12). This mysterious silence may be similar to God's rest on the seventh day of creation (Genesis 2:1–3; see also Hebrews 4:1–11).
- half an hour: This short pause comes before the second act of divine judgment, when God will answer his people's prayers.

Revelation 8:2

Angels sound trumpets dramatically to announce an approaching end (see Isaiah 27:13; Zechariah 9:14; Matthew 24:31; 1 Corinthians 15:52; 1 Thessalonians 4:16).

Revelation 8:2–6

This scene in heaven shows the preparation for the seven trumpets of judgment. It continues the theme of God receiving and answering prayers (Revelation 5:8; 6:9–11).

Revelation 8:2–11.19

- The second series of judgments involves seven trumpets. Like the first series (Revelation 6:1–8:1), it includes a pause (10:1–11:14; compare 7:1–17) and concludes with a view of God's eternal kingdom (11:15–19; see 7:9–8:1).
- The trumpet judgments are similar to the ten plagues of Egypt (Exodus 7:14–11:10). They aim to show that earthly gods (or evil powers) are powerless and to clearly demonstrate God's power and control.

Revelation 8:3–4

The prayers of God's people ask for God's final justice and judgment (Revelation 6:10–11; see also 5:8; Ezra 9:5–6; Psalm 141:2; Daniel 9:21). The mix of incense and prayers that reaches God's presence shows that God hears them (see Revelation 6:9–11) and is ready to act.

Revelation 8:5

- The angel throwing fire down to earth marks the dramatic start of God's judgment (see Genesis 19:24; Exodus 9:23; Leviticus 10:2; Deuteronomy 9:3; 2 Kings 1:10).
- thunder, lightning ... earthquake: These disasters remind us of God's power, presence, and judgment (also Revelation 11:19; 16:18; see Exodus 19:18–19; 1 Kings 19:11–12; Isaiah 29:6).

Revelation 8:7

- Hail and fire mixed with blood show the destruction of plant life, similar to the seventh plague on Egypt (see Exodus 9:13–35; Joel 2:31; Acts 2:19).
- was burned up, along with ... all the green grass: Nothing escapes God's judgment.
- This vision does not need to align with Revelation 9:4 because each scene is independent and conveys its own message.

Revelation 8:7–12

Each of the first four trumpets affects one-third of its target (see Ezekiel 5:1–4, 12; Zechariah 13:8). This does not convey an exact measurement. Instead, it shows that God's judgment on the earth is starting but has not reached its peak. Together, the first four trumpets deliver a unified message of judgment on the entire physical world (as with Revelation 6:1–8).

Revelation 8:8–9

- the sea turned to blood: This judgment is like the first plague on Egypt (see Exodus 7:14–25; Psalm 78:44).
- The mountain of fire resembles the eruption of Mount Vesuvius in AD 79, which destroyed ships and sea life (see Pliny the Younger, Letters 6.16.1–22).

Revelation 8:10–11

The star named Wormwood (a shrubby plant that produces a bitter extract) is symbolic, not physical. Bitter water is linked to judgment from early in Israel's history (Exodus 15:22–26; Numbers 5:18; Jeremiah 9:13–16; 23:15). The message is that widespread judgment has started.

Revelation 8:12

- the fourth angel: On the fourth day of creation, God made the sun, the moon, and the stars (Genesis 1:14–19).
- the stars were darkened: This judgment replicates the ninth plague in Egypt (Exodus 10:21–23).

Revelation 8:13

- In ancient times, people saw the eagle as a messenger from God (see 4 Ezra 11:7–8; 2 Baruch 77:19–26).
- Woe! Woe! Woe: A threefold announcement would be seen as a message from God (see Acts 10:16).
- The terror (Greek ouai), which sounded like an eagle's screech, was directed against those who were not among God's faithful (see Revelation 6:10; 9:4, 20).

Revelation 9:1–12

The fifth trumpet is the first of the three terrors (Revelation 8:13). It brings a judgment of locusts from the bottomless pit, a place of horror. Ancient cultures thought the ocean depths, or the Abyss, was a home for demonic forces (see study note on Genesis 1:2).

Revelation 9:1–21

The fifth and sixth trumpets show how God's judgment affects people worldwide and highlight how worthless it is to resist God. These judgments should lead to repentance, but they do not. Sin controls people so much that they choose to worship the evil forces that harm them instead of repenting and turning to God.

Revelation 9:2

The smoke from the pit made the sky dark, similar to the plague in Egypt (Exodus 10:21–29; see Matthew 27:45).

Revelation 9:3–4

The locusts come down to earth from the smoke. They have the power to sting like scorpions. They are fiercer than those in the Egyptian plague (see Exodus 10:14–15). Instead of eating plants, these locusts attack people like stinging scorpions. Only people without the seal of God (see Revelation 7:1–8) experience this painful judgment. The stings cause painful torture but do not cause death (Revelation 9:5–6).

Revelation 9:5

torment them for five months: This time period is a symbolically complete number based on the fingers on a hand. It is also the normal life span of locusts, suggesting that their entire purpose was to torture people.

Revelation 9:7–10

- Some people view these locusts as symbols of attack helicopters, missiles, or other modern weapons. However, they originate from the Abyss, not from human creation. The description of these creatures, based on the appearance of locusts, is intended to cause fear and disgust.
- Their gold crowns show that their torment affects much of the earth.

Revelation 9:11

- The king of the locusts is identified in three ways:

1. as the angel from the bottomless pit, likely different from the fallen star in Revelation 9:1, who unlocked the abyss instead of coming from it;
2. as Abaddon (meaning "destruction"), often associated with death (see Job 28:22; Psalm 88:11); and
3. as Apollyon, the Destroyer (see 1 Corinthians 10:10).

- Although John does not directly link the devil with this king of the locusts, the prince of demons is associated with Satan in the Gospels (Mark 3:22–26; see Matthew 12:24–27; Luke 11:15–18). The New Testament also identifies the devil as the prince of this world (John 12:31; 14:30; 16:11) and the prince of the power of the air (Ephesians 2:2), suggesting he likely represents Satan. There is also a link to the Roman emperor Domitian, whose patron god Apollo was symbolized by the locust.

Revelation 9:13–14

- The four horns of the gold altar (see Revelation 8:3) appear with the sixth trumpet blast. Many excavations have found altars with pointed horns at their four corners (see study note on Exodus 27:2).
- The voice has God's authority to command the release of the four angels.
- These angels are bound, indicating their evil nature (compare Revelation 20:2; 1 Enoch 10; contrast Revelation 7:1). Their location at the great Euphrates River likely refers to Assyria and Babylon, empires that destroyed the kingdoms of Israel and Judah,

symbolizing destruction (see 2 Kings 17:22–24; 25:1–11).

Revelation 9:15

hour and day and month and year: This four-part time designation shows that even evil forces must follow God's timing.

Revelation 9:16

- The connection between the four angels and their army is unclear.
- two hundred million: This number symbolizes an extremely large group that cannot be counted. Even at its greatest strength, the ancient Roman army with twenty-one legions numbered only about 126,000 soldiers. It is not useful to use this number to identify any specific country with such an overwhelming destructive force.

Revelation 9:17–19

- The riders wore armor in colors matching their horses' plagues:
- red for fire,
- blue for smoke, and
- yellow for sulfur.

These are signs of judgment in Scripture (see Revelation 14:10–11; 19:20; Genesis 19:24–28; Psalm 11:6; Ezekiel 38:22; Luke 17:29).

- The horses resemble the terrifying monsters from Greek stories depicted on ancient buildings and celebrated in old dramas.
- A third: See study note on Revelation 8:7–12.

Revelation 9:20–21

- Even when faced with plagues and death, people do not automatically repent. They often continue their evil actions and worship demons and idols (things from the created world) instead of worshiping the Creator (see Revelation 13:4; 14:9–10; Romans 1:25; 1 Corinthians 8:4; 10:19–22).
- murder, sorcery, sexual immorality, and theft: What people worship reflects how they live (see Revelation 21:8; 22:15; Romans 1:23, 29–32).
- Revelation shows how strongly sin controls people who do not believe. It is not logical for people to worship powers or beings that harm, torture, or kill them. Yet sin and rebellion against God can deceive people and draw them in with great power.

Revelation 10:1

another mighty angel (see Revelation 5:2; 7:2; compare 1:12–16): This angel looks like the large bronze Colossus that stood as a symbol of human power in the harbor of Rhodes for several decades before an earthquake toppled it in the late 200s BC. The statue was still broken when John wrote Revelation. It was about 100 feet tall and represented the sun god, Helios.

The angel was surrounded by a cloud, suggesting he was larger than the Rhodes statue and, by implication, all idols.

The rainbow over his head reminds us that the enthroned God is encircled by a rainbow (Revelation 4:3), a biblical symbol of God's covenant with humanity (Genesis 9:8–17).

Revelation 10:1–11:14

This interlude between the sixth and seventh trumpets has two parts:

1. the seven thunders and the small scroll (Revelation 10:1–11), and
2. the two witnesses (Revelation 11:1–13).

The interlude ends with the announcement that the second terror is over (Revelation 11:14).

Revelation 10:2–3

- Although the scroll is small, it is still very important. It reveals a small but critical part of God's purposes for events that will happen before eternity begins.
- he cried out in a loud voice: Compare Job 37:2–5; Psalm 18:13; Psalm 29:3–4.

Revelation 10:4

Revelation shows God's plans for the world but keeps the mystery of his ways. The martyrs did not get an immediate answer to their cries (Revelation 6:10). The meaning of the seventh seal remains silent (Revelation 8:1). Here, the seven thunders are kept secret (compare Daniel 12:9).

Revelation 10:5–6

- Raising the right hand is common for taking an oath today, but it is rare in the Bible (compare Genesis 14:22; 24:9; Daniel 12:7).
- When making an oath, Jews were careful not to use God's name lightly (see Exodus 20:7). Jesus also corrected people who made oaths without sincerity (see Matthew 5:33–37; 23:16–22). When God made an oath, he used his own name, because there is no

higher authority (see Genesis 22:16; Psalm 89:35–36; Jeremiah 22:5; Hebrews 6:13–18).

Revelation 10:7

- he begins to sound his trumpet: See 1 Corinthians 15:51–54; 1 Thessalonians 4:16.
- God's mysterious plan for the world is not a surprise. The prophets who served God in the past warned that the day of the Lord would come (see Joel 2:1–3, 10–11; Amos 5:18–20; Zephaniah 1:14–18).

Revelation 10:8–10

As in Ezekiel's experience, the scroll tasted sweet in the mouth (Ezekiel 3:1–3; see Jeremiah 15:16; see also Psalms 19:10; 119:103). The future experiences for God's people would be sweet, including the victory of God's plan and the vindication of his people. John's bitter stomach is similar to the effects of Ezekiel's tough message for Israel (Ezekiel 3:8–9). The process of fulfilling God's plan involves hardship.

Revelation 10:11

Unlike Ezekiel, who prophesied only for Israel, John must prophesy about (or against) all the people of the world. There is debate about whether "about" or "against" is the best translation. "About" allows for both promise and judgment (see both in Revelation 21:24–27).

Revelation 11:1

The instructions to measure the temple remind us of Ezekiel's visions (see Ezekiel 40–42; 43:13–17). The Romans destroyed the Jerusalem temple in AD 70. These details symbolize God's precise knowledge and care for his people (compare Revelation 7:2–4; Zechariah 2:1–5).

Revelation 11:1–13

- This section shows people choosing to ignore God's call to repent. Attempts to silence his messengers fail, and God wins.
- Many have tried to identify the two witnesses in this chapter. Moses and Elijah, who appeared with Jesus at the transfiguration (Matthew 17:3; Mark 9:4; Luke 9:30), are likely candidates (see Revelation 11:6). They represent the law and the prophets. Others suggest Enoch and Elijah because they did not die (see Genesis 5:21–24; 2 Kings 2:11–12). Some think of Peter and Paul, or James and John.

More important than their identities is their role in confirming God's message through the testimony of two or three witnesses (see Deuteronomy 17:6). God provides a dual witness to the world about the coming judgment, making it clear that his word will come true (Deuteronomy 19:15; Matthew 18:15–16).

Revelation 11:2–3

- The outer courtyard of the Jerusalem Temple, which was outside the stone warning fence, was considered the place for the Gentile nations. John uses this image to make a clear distinction between the people God recognizes and those he does not.
- The 42 months and 1,260 days represent three and a half years, or an incomplete seven (see study notes on Daniel 7:24–25; 8:26; 9:24–27). John frequently uses these time periods in Revelation when persecution is evident and evil seems to control the world. God's people will remain secure in him (see study note on Revelation 11:1) even though God permits evil forces to persecute them (see Revelation 13:7; Mark 10:30).

Revelation 11:3

- During the period of persecution, God will not abandon the world. He will send two witnesses to announce the coming judgment, similar to how God sent Jonah to Nineveh (Jonah 1:2; 4:11).
- Burlap clothing symbolized mourning or repentance (see Genesis 37:34; 2 Samuel 3:31; Nehemiah 9:1; Esther 4:1; Jonah 3:6).

Revelation 11:4

two olive trees and the two lampstands: See study note on Revelation 1:12; see also Exodus 25:31–40; Zechariah 4:2–6.

Revelation 11:5

In one of the psalms, God is described as having fire coming from his mouth, symbolizing judgment on his enemies (Psalm 18:8; see also 2 Samuel 22:9). Compare with Elijah, 2 Kings 1:1–15.

Revelation 11:6

These two witnesses received the power to stop the rain and bring plagues, similar to Elijah (see 1 Kings 17:1; 18:41–46) and Moses (see Exodus 7:14–24; 8:1–11:10).

Revelation 11:7–8

After the witnesses complete their testimony, the scene changes dramatically. The beast (compare Revelation 13:1) appears for the first time. It is linked to the bottomless pit. Like all enemies of God, the beast fights against God's witnesses and kills them.

Revelation 11:8

- Their bodies will lie in the street of the great city: Evil is so vengeful that it even dishonors the dead.
- the great city: The name "the great city" would have immediately suggested Rome to early readers (Revelation 16:19; 17:18; 18:10, 16, 18–19, 21). However, John also describes it as the city where their Lord was crucified, as well as Sodom and Egypt—all places hostile to God and his people (see also Revelation 17:5, 9).
- where their Lord was also crucified: There is a direct connection between how evil forces treated the Lord and the experiences of persecuted Christians (see Acts 9:5).

Revelation 11:9

- Leaving people's bodies out for public display was a way to dishonor them after death (see 1 Samuel 31:10; the usual Roman custom was to leave bodies hanging after crucifixion).
- peoples and tribes and tongues and nations: This phrase shows that all the peoples of the world are represented in this public display.

Revelation 11:10

And those ... will gloat over them and celebrate: God's enemies dislike and reject his messengers.

Revelation 11:11

- The death of the two witnesses does not end their mission. God was not defeated in the death of Jesus, and he will not be defeated by the death of his witnesses. The God of resurrection breathed life into the dead, making them stand up (see Ezekiel 37:3–5, 10), proving God's power.
- great fear: It is frightening for sinful humans to face the power of the living God (see Hebrews 10:31).

Revelation 11:12

they went up to heaven in a cloud: This event is similar to the way Jesus rose (or ascended) to heaven (see Acts 1:9). It also resembles other ascents found in Scripture (see 2 Kings 2:11–12; 1 Thessalonians 4:17).

Revelation 11:13

- Earthquakes often occur during important events in biblical history (see Exodus 19:18; 1 Kings 19:11–12; Matthew 27:51).
- Seven thousand: This number of deaths shows God's role in judgment (contrast 1 Kings 19:18).
- the rest ... gave glory to the God of heaven: Those who survived the earthquake had to recognize God's power and control over the world (see Philippians 2:9–11).

Revelation 11:15

Loud voices in the court of heaven sing a victory song. The earth has become the kingdom of our Lord and his Christ, who reigns as king forever.

Revelation 11:15–19

The seventh trumpet, also called the third woe (Revelation 11:14; see also 9:12), shows a scene of final judgment and the eternal kingdom. Like in Revelation 7:9–17, this scene offers a dramatic view of the ultimate Christian hope with God. Amidst this picture of judgment, the reader remembers eternity with God.

Revelation 11:16–18

The twenty-four elders, who represent God's people, confirm that God has taken his place as the victorious King (see study note on Revelation 4:4). Their worship recognizes God's sovereign rule as the Almighty (see Revelation 4:10–11; 5:8–10).

Revelation 11:17

The thanksgiving prayer describes God as the one who is and who always was. The phrase is to come (see Revelation 1:4, 8) no longer applies. In this scene, eternity has arrived, and God has begun to reign.

Revelation 11:18

- The nations were angry when they did not follow God's commands (see Psalm 2). But now, things will change because God's anger has arrived. God will reward his holy people (see Revelation 22:12) with new life as his children (see John 1:12; 20:31).
- fear Your name: God's name represents his nature; fearing God's name means accepting who he is (see "Fear of the Lord" Theme Note).
- The end of the age will be the time to destroy those who have not accepted God's love (see John 3:16–20). They will go into the lake of fire (Revelation 20:15). This fate of God's enemies is the third and final terror (Revelation 11:14).

Revelation 11:19

- This verse dramatically concludes the first half of Revelation and connects to the second half.
- In this scene, the temple and the ark symbolize God's presence. The earthly ark was a copy of the heavenly ark's design (see Exodus 25:40; Hebrews 8:5).

Revelation 12:1

The number twelve suggests that the woman represents God's people (compare Revelation 12:15–17; see Jeremiah 2:32; 2 Corinthians 11:2; Ephesians 5:32), from whom the Messiah came. This woman is marked by God's glory, unlike the prostitute (see Revelation 17:1–6), who faces destruction.

Revelation 12:1–17

Satan is shown as a dragon. He plots to oppose God's plans but fails. After losing a direct battle with God and Christ, he tries to harm God's followers. Three short scenes summarize the story (Revelation 12:1–6), followed by details of the war in heaven (12:7–9) and the war on earth (12:13–17).

Revelation 12:1–14.20

The people of God are pictured as a woman who gives birth to the Messiah. Even though the devil has already been defeated, he continues to attack her and her children (Revelation 12:1–17). With his two followers, the beast and the false prophet, Satan tries to keep controlling the world (Revelation 13:1–18) before the final battle with the Lord (14:1–20).

Revelation 12:2

The symbolic woman experiencing the pain of labor represents Christ's birth. This reflects the biblical theme of Israel's struggle while waiting for deliverance (see Isaiah 26:16–18; Jeremiah 4:31; Micah 4:9–10; John 16:21).

Revelation 12:3–4

- The large red dragon symbolizes Satan (see Revelation 12:9).
- seven heads, ten horns: These numbers symbolize a mix of divine and created powers (see Revelation 17:7–14).
- The historic battle between evil and God's people occurs on a cosmic scale (see Genesis 3:1–7, 14–15; Job 1:9–12).
- Herod's wish to kill Jesus showed Satan's attempt to destroy her baby after birth (see Matthew 2:7–8, 16).

Revelation 12:5

- Jesus was the son who was to rule all nations (see Luke 1:31–33; 2:30–32; compare Psalm 2:6–12).
- Although agents of evil killed Jesus, God saved him from the dragon and raised him from the dead (Matthew 28:6; Mark 10:33–34; 16:6; 1 Corinthians 15:3–4). This scene summarizes the life of Jesus on earth, from his birth to his death and resurrection.
- caught up to God and to His throne: See Acts 1:9–11.

Revelation 12:6

- Like the people of Israel who were spiritually refined in the wilderness (see Hosea 2:14–15; Acts 7:38–45) and in exile in Babylon (see Isaiah 5:13; Ezekiel 12:1–3), the Christian church must face its own challenges. Revelation shares messages of endurance and perseverance during difficult times and shows that God provides places of refuge and ways to escape for his people (compare 1 Corinthians 10:13).
- 1,260 days: See study note on Revelation 11:2–3.

Revelation 12:7–9

- This scene reveals the dragon's identity and power.
- God sends Michael, the warrior archangel (see Daniel 12:1; Jude 1:9), to face the dragon and his angels. God does not need to fight the battle himself (see Matthew 26:53), and Satan is defeated.

Revelation 12:10–11

Satan's defeat encourages Christians who, like those in Revelation, do not fear death (see John 12:24–26).

Revelation 12:13

when the dragon saw: The scene continues from Revelation 12:9.

Revelation 12:14

- two wings of a great eagle (see Exodus 19:4–6; Deuteronomy 32:10–11; Isaiah 40:29–31): God strengthens his people but does not promise they will avoid persecution or death.
- a time, and times, and half a time: This is usually understood as three and a half years (see Revelation 11:2–3).

Revelation 12:15–16

John imagines Satan as Leviathan, a great sea monster (compare Job 41:1), trying to destroy God's people (the woman; see study note on Revelation 12:1). In the vision, the earth protects the woman, and the dangerous waters are held back. This is similar to the way God contained the waters of chaos at creation (compare Genesis 1:2, 6–7, 9–10).

Revelation 12:17

The dragon becomes hostile towards the woman's children, who are believers. They follow God's commandments and continue to testify about Jesus.

Revelation 12:18

on the shore of the sea: By contrast, the lamb stands on the rock of Zion (Revelation 12:17).

Revelation 12:18–13.18

John shows that the dragon carries out his war (Revelation 12:17) through two beasts. Together with Satan, these three form an evil trinity, meaning three evil beings acting together as one group.

Revelation 13:1

The beast comes out of the sea, symbolizing evil. Like the dragon, it has seven heads and ten horns (see Revelation 12:3). The crowns show its political and military power (compare Revelation 17:3, 7–11; Daniel 7:7, 19–20) and indicate that Satan leads this beast's empire.

Revelation 13:1–10

The first beast is the second member of the evil trinity (see study note on Revelation 12:18–13:18). It likely represents Roman power (see "Four World Empires" Theme Note).

Revelation 13:2

Satan turns the beast into a false god by giving it his power, throne, and authority. In the first century, Roman emperors often claimed to be gods.

Revelation 13:3

- Satan often imitates God. Here, the beast copies the death and resurrection of Jesus.
- One of the beast's heads appears to have been fatally wounded but then healed. This detail has led many interpreters to connect the beast with the Roman emperor Nero, who ruled from AD 54 to 68. A tradition developed that Nero was so evil that he either did not really die or would return as another tyrant like Domitian, who ruled from AD 81 to 96. In Revelation 17:9–10, the beast's seven heads are linked to both seven hills (Rome) and seven kings.

Revelation 13:5

The forty-two months represent three and a half years of persecution and evil rule (see study note on Revelation 11:2–3).

Revelation 13:5–8

The four characteristics of the beast are:

1. he speaks against God,
2. he holds power for a short time,
3. he fights against God's people, and
4. he governs the world.

However, God remains in control.

Revelation 13:7

The beast has power over all the people in the world.

Revelation 13:8

People who worshiped the beast received its mark (Revelation 13:15–17) and are not in the Book of Life (see 20:12).

Revelation 13:9–10

The scene (Revelation 13:1–10) ends with a dramatic conclusion similar to Jeremiah 15:2; 43:11. Anyone who can hear must listen, because judgment is coming (compare Revelation 2:7, 11, 17).

Revelation 13:10

God's holy people are called to stay strong and faithful during temporary persecution.

Revelation 13:11

- The beast appears as a lamb, the same symbol used for Christ (see Revelation 5:6–13; 7:9–17; 14:1–4), but this lamb spoke like a dragon. This image represents a false messiah.
- The two horns might symbolize two emperors, possibly Nero and Domitian.

Revelation 13:11–18

another beast: This second beast, the third member of the evil trinity (see study note on Revelation 12:18–13:18), is later called the false prophet (16:13). As a high priest of false religion, he leads the world to worship the first beast and the dragon (see also 16:13–14).

Revelation 13:12

- caused the earth ... to worship the first beast: Rome under the rule of the emperor demanded that people worship Emperor Domitian.
- whose mortal wound had been healed: This description might point to Domitian, who many believed was a return, or reincarnation, of Nero (see study note on Revelation 13:3). The image represents the constant return of evil, especially in the last days (see study note on Revelation 17:8).

Revelation 13:12–15

The second beast gets its power from the first beast, which follows the dragon (Revelation 13:4).

Revelation 13:13–15

In New Testament times, false prophets amazed people with stories of divine visits and idols speaking for the gods they represented (see Acts 16:16–18; 1 Corinthians 12:2–3). These practices involved worshiping demons (see 1 Corinthians 10:20–21) and were highlighted in the Roman emperor cult. Those who refused to follow were executed.

Revelation 13:14–15

it was given ... was permitted: God never gives up ultimate authority. These evil creatures can rebel against God, but they are not in control.

Revelation 13:16–17

- small and great, rich and poor, free and slave: Everyone must accept the beast's evil mark of ownership (see Revelation 14:9, 11; 19:20; 20:4). This mark is needed to buy or sell. The text does not clearly describe what the mark is or how it looks.
- On the right hand or forehead suggests the branding of slaves, showing the beast owns them.
- the name of the beast or the number of its name: In both Hebrew and Greek, letters of the alphabet stand for numbers, giving names a numerical value (Revelation 13:18).

Revelation 13:18

- a call for wisdom: John gives a clue to help his readers understand the meaning of the beast's number.
- of a man: John hides the man's identity, possibly to protect himself and his readers from danger (compare the use of Babylon as a symbol for Rome, Revelation 17:9).
- The number 666 represents supernatural evil (see "Symbolic Numbers" Theme Note). John might have used the transliteration Caesar Neron (a Hebrew spelling of the name) to reach the number 666. Later scribes, who spoke Greek but not Hebrew, changed the number to 616 in some manuscripts, likely to match the name's numerical value in Greek.

Revelation 14:1

- standing: See Revelation 5:6; study note on Revelation 12:18.
- 144,000: God's righteous remnant (see study note on Revelation 7:4–8).
- The mark on their foreheads (contrast Revelation 13:16–17) is the name of both the lamb and his father, showing the unity of Jesus and the Father (see John 5:20–23; 14:5–10; 17:22).

Revelation 14:1–5

The true lamb and his followers are very different from the evil trinity.

Revelation 14:2–3

This great choir sang a new song that only those redeemed from the earth could learn. These people had died and were already with the Lord. This might explain why John did not include the content of their refrain for readers still facing life's challenges (compare 2 Corinthians 12:4).

Revelation 14:4–5

- These warriors were ceremonially pure (not ... defiled) and morally blameless.
- for they are virgins: Referring to men as virgins is a metaphor for the faithfulness of God's people. The image might refer to the church as the virgin bride of Christ (see 2 Corinthians 11:2; Ephesians 5:25–27). It also suggests that the church members are like soldiers in a holy war who must abstain from sexual intercourse (see Deuteronomy 23:9–10; 1 Samuel 21:5).
- These faithful people are a special offering, literally called firstfruits (see Exodus 13:14–16; 23:19; Leviticus 23:9–14; Numbers 3:40–51; 18:15–20; Luke 2:22–24), who have been purchased for God.
- no lie was found in their mouths: John teaches that liars will never enter heaven (Revelation 21:8, 27; 22:15; see also John 8:44). The followers of Jesus speak and live the truth (see also John 8:32; 14:6).

Revelation 14:6–7

The first angel announces the eternal good news. This includes the message that God will judge soon. It is a final call to repent.

Revelation 14:6–13

Three angels fly through the sky carrying messages from God.

Revelation 14:8

Babylon likely symbolizes Rome (see Revelation 16:19; 17:5–9). It represents earthly power and corruption. God's arrival as judge (Revelation 14:7) signifies the end of earthly powers.

Revelation 14:9–11

- The third angel announces God's judgment (Revelation 14:7) on the false worship of the beast and his statue (see Revelation 13:12–18; 19:20; 20:4). God responds to the rebellion against his rule with anger,

shown as a cup of bitter wine (see Revelation 16; 19:15).
- fire and sulfur ... smoke: This description of judgment (see also Revelation 19:20; 20:10, 14–15) reminds us of God's judgment on Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 18:16–19:28).
- Those condemned to a fiery end will suffer in the presence of the holy angels and the Lamb (compare Luke 16:22–24).

Revelation 14:12

Christians who first read this letter faced real threats of persecution and death. John urges God's people to obey and stay faithful (see Revelation 2:10; 3:10; 12:17; 13:10).

Revelation 14:13

- A powerful voice from heaven tells John to write again (see Revelation 1:11, 19; 21:5; compare 10:4).
- Blessed are ... those who die in the Lord: God wants those who suffer persecution to be with him and enjoy his blessings and rest.
- Mentioning hard work and good deeds with eternal reward hints at rewards given based on actions (Revelation 20:12).

Revelation 14:14

- the Son of Man: Or like a son of man; see study note on Revelation 1:13.
- A gold crown symbolizes status or power, clearly distinguishing Jesus from the angels (see Revelation 4:4; 6:2; 9:7; 12:3; 13:1).
- The sharp sickle symbolizes God's harvest of judgment (see Revelation 14:17–18; see also Jeremiah 51:33; Hosea 6:11; Micah 4:12–13).

Revelation 14:14–20

Two short scenes show God's judgment.

Revelation 14:15–18

The temple and the altar symbolize God's presence (see Revelation 9:13; 11:19; 16:7).

Revelation 14:18–20

- The ripe grapes (see Amos 8:2) trampled in the winepress highlight God's power to judge (see Revelation 19:15; Joel 3:13).
- People built winepresses outside cities and towns; here, the city is Jerusalem. The bloody river of death stretched about 290 kilometers (180 miles). This shows that God's enemies have no chance when the Son of Man comes in judgment. This destruction is closely linked with the final battle in Revelation 19:17–21. God is just and fair in giving people exactly what they deserve (see Revelation 16:5–7).

Revelation 15:1

This series of seven final plagues (Revelation 15:1–16:21) completes God's punishment of his enemies (see 16:17; Amos 1–2; Romans 1:18–2:16). Revelation revisits the topic of God's punishment later (Revelation 19:15–21).

Revelation 15:1–16.21

The third and final cycle of seven judgments (see study note on Revelation 6:1–16:21) begins with a vision of God's victorious people singing a hymn of praise (Revelation 15:2–4). Then, a scene of the temple appears (Revelation 15:5–8), where angels come out carrying the bowls of God's judgment for the earth (16:1–21).

Revelation 15:2

The glass sea mixed with fire symbolizes victory through testing. Those who defeated the beast (see Revelation 13:1–8, 15–18) hold harps that represent ultimate peace. Their position on the sea of glass (compare Revelation 4:6) symbolizes their endurance through the fire of persecution (compare Psalm 66:12; Isaiah 43:2; Daniel 3:8–30).

Revelation 15:3

- O Lord God Almighty! (see also Revelation 1:8; 4:8; 11:17; 16:7; 19:6; 21:22): For persecuted Christians, knowing that God is all-powerful brings comfort and security.
- The fact that God is just and true supports human integrity in a confused, unjust, and dishonest world.
- God is the supreme, universal King of the nations, not a local deity tied to one nation or a human ruler with limited power.

Revelation 15:3–4

The song of Moses and the Lamb shows that God's purposes in the old covenant (God's earlier promise and relationship with his people) and the new covenant (his promise through Jesus) are united and work together.

Revelation 15:4

- Who will not fear ... and glorify Your name?: This rhetorical question (see Jeremiah 10:7) suggests that only a fool would fail to do so (see Revelation 14:7; 16:9; Psalms 14:1; 53:1).

- You alone are holy: See Revelation 16:5; Leviticus 11:44; 1 Peter 1:16. God's holiness is the reason for our worship and salvation.
- All nations will come and worship: Some will be forced to acknowledge God (compare Philippians 2:10–11), but all will recognize that God's deeds and judgments are revealed, righteous, and just.

Revelation 15:5–6

- God's tabernacle shows God's presence (see John 1:14). Even the plagues come from God's presence. Christ's sacrifice (Matthew 27:51; Mark 15:38; Hebrews 6:19–20; 10:19–20) removed the barrier between God and humanity (see Exodus 26:31–35; Leviticus 16). Now, those who do not belong to Christ feel the full impact of God's presence (see Revelation 20:11–15; Isaiah 13:4–12; Zephaniah 2:1–3; Malachi 3:2–3).
- bright linen: Linen, a symbol of purity, was also worn by priests during their duties (see Exodus 28:39–43; Leviticus 16:4, 23; see also Ezekiel 9:2–3; Daniel 12:6–7). These angels do not intercede; they are agents of judgment. The linen represents the purity and justice of God's judgment.
- The gold sashes across their chests likely symbolize their divine mission as ministers of justice for God (compare Revelation 1:13).

Revelation 15:7

- the four living creatures: See Revelation 4:6–8.
- seven golden bowls: These bowls are likely similar to the offering pans used in ancient worship (see Exodus 37:16).

Revelation 15:8

Smoke filled the temple to show God's glory and power (Isaiah 6:4; see Exodus 19:16–18; 40:34–35; 1 Kings 8:10–13).

Revelation 16:1

The powerful voice likely belongs to God (also in Revelation 6:6; 9:13; 16:17; 18:4; 19:5; see Isaiah 66:6).

Revelation 16:1–21

These seven bowls filled with God's wrath symbolize the final judgments on the world. With the seventh bowl, a voice from God's throne shouts, It is done! (Revelation 16:17; compare John 19:30).

Revelation 16:2

- The harmful sores remind us of the sixth plague in Egypt (Exodus 9:9–11).
- mark of the beast: See Revelation 13:13–17; 14:9–10.

Revelation 16:3–4

The plagues of the second and third bowls are similar to the first plague of Egypt (Exodus 7:17–21). John may have thought about how much of Rome's food and wealth came from the sea. After Julius Caesar cleared the sea of pirates, shipping became vital for Rome. Its end would mean economic collapse for the empire (see Revelation 18:17–19).

Revelation 16:5–6

the angel of the waters: In Scripture, angels and archangels are shown to have special roles within the order of heaven (see Daniel 8:16; 9:21; 10:13, 21; 12:1; Luke 1:19, 26; see also 1 Enoch 66:1–2). This angel confirms that these judgments come from God, who is just and holy.

Revelation 16:6

Punishing God's enemies is fair because they killed God's holy people and prophets. Since they shed blood, they must drink blood. The principle of lex talionis (the law of retribution), which is the basis of Roman and Jewish law, shows that God is completely fair in judging and rewarding people based on their actions (see Revelation 2:23; 11:18; 14:13; 18:6; 20:12, 13; 22:12).

Revelation 16:7

I heard the altar reply: The response to the angel's proclamation (Revelation 16:5–6) confirms God's authority and justice. This praise during judgment reminds persecuted Christians that God cares about his suffering servants and fulfills his purpose in everything.

Revelation 16:8–9

- The fourth bowl is different from the plagues of Egypt, earlier seals, or trumpets.
- the people were scorched: Contrast Revelation 7:16. Yet those who faced this judgment refused to repent or honor God (see Revelation 9:20–21; 16:11; compare 14:6–7); they even cursed God's name.

Revelation 16:10–11

- the throne of the beast: John might be referring to Rome, the political power of his time. Built on seven hills (Revelation 17:9), Rome's empire stretched across the sea (13:1) and dominated the world (13:7).
- plunged into darkness: This is similar to the ninth plague of Egypt (Exodus 10:22) and the fourth trumpet (Revelation 8:12).

- gnaw their tongues. ... curse the God of heaven: Pain and anger caused these reactions to punishment (compare Matthew 8:12; 13:42, 50; 22:13; 24:51; 25:30; Luke 13:28).

Revelation 16:12

The Euphrates, the largest river in Mesopotamia, lay between Babylon and Israel. It marked the eastern border of the Roman Empire. If it dried up, kings from the east could move their armies westward (compare Revelation 9:13–16). From John's perspective as an ancient Jewish writer, people would always associate these armies with Mesopotamia, not with countries farther east like China or India.

Revelation 16:13–14

Three deceitful agents, evil spirits in the form of frogs, symbolize the demonic role of the evil trinity. Although evil powers fight against the Lord, God the Almighty, not any evil power, remains in control.

Revelation 16:15

Readers are warned to stay alert because the Lord will come as unexpectedly as a thief (see also Revelation 3:3; Matthew 24:43; 25:13; 1 Thessalonians 5:2; 2 Peter 3:10). Being ready for his coming requires preparation. Those who are not prepared will lack proper clothing and will find themselves exposed (see Matthew 22:11–13). This imagery refers to two failing churches:

- lifeless Sardis, which is told to "wake up" (Revelation 3:2), and
- lukewarm Laodicea, which is advised to get proper clothing (Revelation 3:18).

Revelation 16:16

The name Armageddon (or Harmagedon) likely comes from the Hebrew words har (which means "mountain" or "hill") and Megiddo. Solomon fortified Megiddo along with Gezer in the south and Hazor in the north (1 Kings 9:15). The fortress of Megiddo stood on a hill in the largest pass through the Carmel range, strategically guarding the Jezreel Valley.

The city was on the Via Maris, the main highway between Egypt and Mesopotamia. Many armies used this route, making the site known for bloody battles. For example, Pharaoh Neco killed Josiah here on his way to fight the Assyrians (2 Kings 23:29). Armageddon became a symbol for the final conflict between God and the forces of evil.

Revelation 16:17

When the seventh bowl is poured out, something unexpected happens. God's enemies gather for battle. But at the crucial moment, instead of a battle, there is a shout: It is done! Jesus spoke these same words from the cross when he completed his work (John 19:30). No one can ultimately fight against God. This scene shows the end of rebellion against God. What follows are different descriptions of the end.

Revelation 16:18–20

This judgment scene repeats the events showing the world's destruction (Revelation 6:12–14; 11:13). It also hints at the final judgment (Revelation 20:11–15) when the earth will be taken apart to allow for a new creation (21:1; compare Isaiah 45:2; Romans 8:19–22).

Revelation 16:21

- Despite the severity of these plagues, people around the world cursed God instead of understanding his reasons for the judgments (see Revelation 9:20; 16:9, 11).
- The terrible hailstorm reminds us of the seventh plague on Egypt (Exodus 9:23–24).

Revelation 17:1

One of the angels who carry out God's judgment speaks to John and calls him to a new scene. In this scene, John sees the coming judgment of the great prostitute, who rules over many waters.

Rome, which stood on the Tiber River, controlled major centers of power and the water trade routes across the Mediterranean world. Its influence reached from the British Isles to the Euphrates River.

Revelation 17:1–19.10

The main drama in this section shows the powers that stand against God and cause the persecution and suffering of God's people. Rome's power attracted and impressed many people (Revelation 17:6). John clearly describes Rome's sins and shares God's judgment (Revelation 17:3–18) before he describes Rome's fall (18:1–24) and heaven's response to that fall (19:1–10).

Revelation 17:2

- immoral with her: This is a biblical image for worshiping other gods (see, for example, Exodus 34:12–16; Judges 2:17; Hosea 2).
- intoxicated with ... her immorality: In Scripture, drunkenness often represents nations that engage in reckless and immoral behavior (see Revelation

18:3, 9; Jeremiah 25:27; 51:7; Lamentations 4:21; Ezekiel 23:33).

Revelation 17:3–4

- John is taken in the spirit into the wilderness, which he uses to describe a visionary experience (see Revelation 1:10; 4:2). He sees a representation of Rome's moral decay and extreme luxury (see Revelation 18:12–13, 16). This shows how such wealth can be offensive to God.
- The beast here resembles the second figure in the evil trinity (see Revelation 13:1–4).
- blasphemous names: See Revelation 13:5–6.
- purple and scarlet: Clothing in these colors signified royalty and immorality, respectively.
- a golden cup: See Jeremiah 51:7.

Revelation 17:5

In symbolic language, John likely referred to Rome (see Revelation 17:9) as BABYLON THE GREAT, THE MOTHER OF PROSTITUTES. Babylon symbolized the world's idolatries and evil acts. As the MOTHER, she produced followers who imitated her behavior. Rome, like Babylon, worshipped false gods and led other nations into unfaithfulness and idol worship.

Revelation 17:6

God's holy people were witnesses for Jesus, even shedding their blood (see Revelation 16:6; Hebrews 12:4). During John's time, Rome caused this persecution.

Revelation 17:7

The angel helps John understand the mystery in response to his amazement (Revelation 17:8–14).

Revelation 17:8

- The beast ... it was, and now is no more, but is about to come up: When Domitian was emperor, from AD 81 to 96, he was as evil as Nero. Both fiercely persecuted the church. Many believed Domitian embodied Nero's spirit or was Nero himself. This is similar to how people thought John the Baptist embodied Elijah's spirit (see Malachi 4:5; Matthew 11:14; Luke 1:17; John 1:21).
- you saw: The past tense shows the angel explained this after John's vision.
- it was, and now is no more: This contrasts with God, who is and was and is to come (Revelation 1:4, 8).
- the Abyss: See study note on Revelation 9:1–12.
- Unlike God's people, the people of this world are not in the Book of Life (see Revelation 20:11–15). They will be amazed by the beast's apparent resurrection (see study note on Revelation 17:10–11; see also 13:13–17).

Revelation 17:8–11

This vision's destruction contrasts with the future of God's people in the new heaven and earth (see Revelation 21:1–4).

Revelation 17:9

- The seven heads of the beast symbolize the seven hills where Rome was built (refer to study note on Revelation 16:10–11).
- the woman: See Revelation 17:3–6.

Revelation 17:10–11

- Five have fallen: If these kings represent Roman emperors, and we start counting from the change from a republic to an empire with Augustus, who ruled from 29 BC to AD 14, then the fifth would be Nero, who ruled from AD 54 to 68, the sixth would be Vespasian, and the seventh would be Titus. The eighth king would be Domitian.
- that was, and now is not: Early commentators argued that Domitian embodied Nero's spirit (see study note on Revelation 17:8).
- the other seven: This seemingly unbeatable ruler was also destined for destruction.

Revelation 17:12–13

The ten horns, which symbolize world kingdoms following the beast, rule together under his guidance. These verses have led to speculation about a ten-nation alliance. People have guessed it could be the client kingdoms of Rome, the states against the Holy Roman Empire, or the European Union. However, these guesses miss the main point: all nations opposing God will be defeated (Revelation 17:14).

Revelation 17:14

No matter how much power the beast and ten kings gather (Revelation 17:11–12), they cannot win because Jesus is the Lord of all lords (see 19:11–16). Those whom God has called and chosen, and who stay faithful, will stand with him as victors.

Revelation 17:15–16

Although the prostitute controls the masses, she does not win. Instead, the beast hates and kills her. Satan harms even those he uses for evil.

Revelation 17:17

John reminds us that God is in control. God places a plan in the enemy's mind to fulfill his divine purposes (for example, Exodus 7:3; 35:31–35; Ezra 7:27; Romans 9:18, 21).

Revelation 18:1

This angel got his brightness from heaven. The word glory usually describes a divine presence.

Revelation 18:1–3

The angel's powerful taunt song is the first poetic response. Ancient taunt songs mocked a defeated enemy (see Isaiah 13:19–22; 34:10–17). These taunts describe the fall of Babylon (or Rome; see study note on Revelation 14:8) as a traumatic event for dependent kingdoms and especially for those who had benefited from her wealth. The Goths and Visigoths attacked Rome in the AD 400s, ending the prosperous empire.

Revelation 18:1–24

This chapter includes seven poetic responses to the fall of Babylon or Rome (refer to the study note on Revelation 17:5).

Revelation 18:2

Fallen, fallen is Babylon: See Isaiah 21:9. Once a beautifully dressed woman (see Revelation 17:4), Babylon (Rome) became a deserted place for demons and unclean birds like vultures (compare Isaiah 13:20–22; Jeremiah 4:23–31; 50:39).

Revelation 18:3

Rome took wealth from conquered nations, living in extreme luxury, before facing God's justice.

Revelation 18:4

you will not share in her sins: Being connected to the evil city might result in sharing its punishment and even engaging in its sins (see Genesis 13:8–13; 19:1–29; compare Jeremiah 51:6, 45).

Revelation 18:4–8

This second poetic response (see study note on Revelation 18:1–24) warns from heaven to escape the doomed city.

Revelation 18:5

God has remembered: His response may seem slow (Psalm 103:8; 145:8; Joel 2:13; Jonah 4:2), but God is not weak. He does not forget good or evil (Revelation 16:19; Genesis 19:29; 1 Samuel 1:19).

Revelation 18:6

pay her back double: Some sins were so severe that they required double repayment (see Exodus 22:4, 7, 9; compare Isaiah 40:2; Jeremiah 16:18; 17:18).

Revelation 18:7

I sit as queen: Compare Ezekiel 28:1–2.

Revelation 18:8

The plagues (Revelation 18:2–3) remind us that destruction was not just a human action. The Lord God judges her. He is mighty and able to do what he promises.

Revelation 18:9–10

The kings of the world mourn the loss of the luxury they gained from their alliance with the wicked city.

Revelation 18:9–19

These three laments show the sadness of those who gained the most from the sinful city's wealthy lifestyle (compare Ezekiel 27).

Revelation 18:10

The kings, feeling scared and abandoned (see Revelation 18:15, 17), stand far away, trying in vain to escape punishment.

Revelation 18:11–17

The merchants of the world sing the second lament (Revelation 18:14; see study note on Revelation 18:9–19). They made money from the Roman economy (Revelation 18:12–13), but their trade stopped when the great city was quickly destroyed.

Revelation 18:12–13

This cargo list shows how much wealth Rome took from its empire (compare Ezekiel 27:12–24). It mentions some of the most expensive products of the ancient world, criticizing excessive materialism and pride.

Revelation 18:13

bodies: Rome had a large slave market, with historians estimating slaves made up nearly 20% of the population.

Revelation 18:14–17

The merchants would mourn the fall of Rome (see study note on Revelation 18:1–3) because it would permanently end their usual luxuries. Material goods can disappear in an instant.

Revelation 18:17–19

every shipmaster: Seafarers sing the third lament (see study note on Revelation 18:9–19). They mourn the breakdown of communication and transportation. During Julius Caesar's reign, the Mediterranean was cleared of pirates, and trade flourished under Roman law enforcement. The quick loss of Roman authority would disrupt the trade system.

Revelation 18:20

The laments (Revelation 18:9–19) prompt a call for heaven to rejoice. The people of God should not grieve because the judgment was for them. They had suffered persecution from the evil forces symbolized by the great city.

Revelation 18:21

a stone the size of a great millstone: People used heavy millstones, shaped for grinding olives or grain, throughout the ancient world. Jesus also mentioned using such stones for judgment (see Matthew 18:6). The dramatically thrown boulder symbolized that Rome's power was permanently destroyed.

Revelation 18:21–24

The songs about Babylon's fall (Revelation 18:1–24) end with a description of the city's destruction.

Revelation 18:23

Compare Jeremiah 25:10–11.

Revelation 19:1–2

This scene emphasizes what John heard instead of what he saw. A large crowd offers the first three-part praise (compare Revelation 7:9–10).

Revelation 19:1–10

This section expands on the message of the sixth song of response (Revelation 18:20; see study note on Revelation 18:1–24), which called for rejoicing. Various groups offer praises to the Lord. The praises can be divided into two sections:

- thankfulness for the destruction of evildoers (Revelation 19:1–4) and
- thankfulness for the reward of God's people (19:5–8).

Revelation 19:2

true and just (see Revelation 15:3; 16:7): In his righteous justice, God fulfilled his promise to judge the great prostitute, who symbolizes moral and spiritual corruption and the persecution of God's people.

Revelation 19:3

Her smoke: God's people praise him again when they see the fall of the evil city (compare Revelation 14:11).

Revelation 19:4

- In response to the first two praises (Revelation 19:1–3), the elders and the living beings (see Revelation 4) again bow before God on the throne (see Revelation 4:10; 5:8, 14; 7:11).
- Amen: See study note on Revelation 5:14.

Revelation 19:6–8

The final loud Hallelujah emphasizes that God rules as the all-powerful being (see Revelation 1:8; 4:8; 11:17; 15:3; 16:7, 14; 19:15; 21:22).

Revelation 19:7

For the marriage of the Lamb: This event, the wedding of the Messiah with his bride, the church (see Isaiah 54:5; 61:10; Jeremiah 31:32; Ezekiel 16:7–14; Hosea 2:16–20; Mark 2:19–20; 2 Corinthians 11:2), symbolizes complete victory and eternal fellowship.

Revelation 19:8

- fine linen: See study note on Revelation 15:5–6.
- the righteous acts of the saints: See Ephesians 2:8–10; 2 Timothy 3:16–17; James 2:18–22.

Revelation 19:9

- Blessed are those: This fourth blessing in Revelation (see Revelation 1:3; 14:13; 16:15) confirms the hope of the faithful.
- who are invited: God decides who will join.
- marriage supper (compare Revelation 19:17): Jesus often used meals to explain the kingdom (Matthew 22:1–13; Luke 14:7–24), and he established a meal for the church (Mark 14:22–25; 1 Corinthians 11:23–26).
- These are true words: This promise guarantees the message is trustworthy.

Revelation 19:10

The angel gives a strong warning against worshiping the wrong things (compare Revelation 22:8–9).

Revelation 19:11

The rider serves as both a judge and a righteous warrior (see Isaiah 11:1–5). He is called Faithful and True, representing God's authenticity and reliability (see Revelation 19:2; 21:5–6).

Revelation 19:11–16

Then I saw: John describes a new vision of Jesus Christ as a holy warrior and conquering king (see Revelation 14:1; see also Exodus 15:1–7; Psalms 24:8; 78:49–50; Isaiah 59:16–17).

Revelation 19:11–20.15

The drama reaches its peak: God's enemies face defeat and punishment in two episodes (Revelation 19:11–21; 20:7–10). Meanwhile, the faithful enjoy a 1,000-year resurrection (Revelation 20:1–6) followed by the final judgment (20:11–15).

Revelation 19:12

- He has eyes like blazing fire: See Revelation 1:14–16; Daniel 10:6.
- Christ, wearing many crowns, contrasts with the dragon, whose seven heads each had a crown (see Revelation 12:3).

Revelation 19:13

- He is dressed in a robe dipped in blood: This may refer to:

1. the blood of Christ's enemies, showing his complete victory (Isaiah 63:2–4); or
2. Christ's sacrificial death for humanity (Revelation 1:7).

- The Word of God is John's unique name for Jesus (see John 1:1, 14).

Revelation 19:14

Christ's heavenly armies, dressed in victorious white and riding on white horses, contrast with:

- the locust forces from the abyss (Revelation 9:3–11),
- the three frog-like evil spirits (Revelation 16:13), and
- the defeated armies at Armageddon (Revelation 16:16; see also 19:19).

Revelation 19:15

- from His mouth ... a sharp sword: See Revelation 1:16; Hebrews 4:12; see also Isaiah 49:2; 2 Thessalonians 2:8.
- The iron rod symbolizes Christ's power as ruler and supreme shepherd (see Psalms 2:9; 23:4).
- God the Almighty: See Revelation 1:8; 4:8; 11:17; 16:7, 14; 21:22.
- His fierce wrath will crush his enemies like grapes in a winepress (Isaiah 63:2–4).

Revelation 19:16

KING ... LORD: See Revelation 1:5; 15:3; 17:14.

Revelation 19:17–19

gather together for the great supper: This feast on the flesh of the armies fighting against Christ contrasts with the marriage of the Lamb (Revelation 19:7). The enemies ready for battle are quickly destroyed (Revelation 19:20–21; see also 14:17–20; 16:16–21). Two feasts (the marriage supper of the Lamb in Revelation 19:7–8 and the "great supper" of God's judgment in Revelation 19:17–18, 21) offer two views on the end of time. They show the two sides of the good news:

- grace and judgment, and
- reward and punishment (compare John 3:16–18).

Revelation 19:20

- the beast ... the false prophet: See Revelation 13:1–10.
- The fiery lake of burning sulfur symbolizes eternal punishment (see Revelation 20:10, 14–15; 21:8; see also Isaiah 66:24; Matthew 13:41, 49–50; Mark 9:43, 48).
- God's enemies are thrown into the fiery lake. The two beasts (Revelation 19:20) are followed by the dragon (20:10) and then by death (20:14) and unsaved humans (20:15).

Revelation 19:21

The entire enemy army is defeated by the sword from Christ's mouth (see Revelation 1:16; 2:12, 16; see also Isaiah 11:4; 49:2; 2 Thessalonians 2:8). One side of God's word (grace) leads to repentance, while the other side (judgment) delivers the death sentence.

Revelation 20:1–2

Like the Old Testament angel of the LORD (see Genesis 16:7–11; 22:15; Exodus 3:2; Numbers 22:22–34; Judges 2:1–4; 6:11–22), the angel coming down from heaven has God's authority. This is symbolized by the key that controls the bottomless pit and the power to chain God's great enemy (see Revelation 12:7–9) for a thousand years.

See the "The Thousand Years (The Millennium)" Theme Note.

Revelation 20:1–10

This passage has three parts:

- the binding of Satan (Revelation 20:1–3),
- the reign of God's holy people (Revelation 20:4–6), and
- Satan's release for a final battle attempt (Revelation 20:7–10).

Four themes emerge:

1. Satan's war is pointless—he cannot resist even an angel;
2. God's holy people will be justified and honored;
3. God will achieve the final victory; and
4. even when sinful people experience Christ's good purposes, they still follow Satan when he gains some freedom to act.

Revelation 20:3

- This imprisonment, described as a bottomless pit (Abyss), represents an initial defeat for Satan and the forces of evil. Various New Testament passages explain how Christ's work impacts Satan (Luke 10:17–20; Acts 10:38; 26:18; Romans 16:20; Ephesians 6:11; James 4:7; see Matthew 12:24; 16:19; 18:18; John 12:31; 1 John 3:8). Christ's presence with his followers restrains evil powers (see 2 Thessalonians 2:7), reminding persecuted Christians that they have a future with God.
- he could not deceive: Deception is the devil's hallmark, as he is a liar (see John 8:44; 1 John 3:8); no liar will enter heaven (Revelation 21:8, 27; 22:15). Faithful believers who experience Christ's reign will not be deceived.
- The brief period of time might symbolize the three and a half years (see Revelation 11:2–3, 9–11; 12:14; 13:5)—it is a limited time.

Revelation 20:4

- thrones, and those seated on them: This image of a heavenly court includes the elders (Revelation 4:4) on thrones (see Daniel 7:9–10), the victorious martyrs (see Daniel 7:22), and all of God's people.
- beheaded for ... Jesus: Beheading was a common execution method for Roman citizens.
- The faithful who refused the mark of the beast (Revelation 13:16–17) will judge the condemned (see 1 Corinthians 6:2–3) on thrones like those of the worshiping elders (see Revelation 4:10–11; 5:8–10; 11:16).

Revelation 20:5–6

John compares the first resurrection with the second death (see Revelation 20:12–15; compare John 5:29).

Revelation 20:6

Blessed: This fifth blessing in Revelation (see also Revelation 1:3; 14:13; 16:15; 19:9; 22:7, 14) highlights the promised reward of life. God's faithful people (Revelation 20:4) will reign with Christ as priests of God (see also 1:6; 5:10).

Revelation 20:7–8

When Satan is free to act (Revelation 20:7), he still tries to deceive. He will gather a large army (compare Ezekiel 38–39) in a final attempt to defeat God's people (Revelation 20:9).

Revelation 20:7–10

Satan's attempt to defeat God's people ends with his fiery destruction. This passage has two main purposes:

1. to demonstrate God's complete justice, as Satan and his followers deserve punishment and will not change; and
2. to highlight the corruption of those who follow Satan. Even after witnessing Christ's rule for many years, they still join Satan when he is released.

These reasons form the basis for the judgment at the great white throne (Revelation 20:11–15).

Revelation 20:8

- Jewish traditions differ on where Gog and Magog are located. Symbolically, they are to the north (see Jeremiah 1:14–15), the direction from which enemies traditionally approached Megiddo and Jerusalem. The names represent nations and rulers from all over the earth that oppose God's people (see Ezekiel 38–39).
- to assemble them for battle: This repeats earlier scenes where God's enemies gather for battle (Revelation 16:16; 19:19). Here, Satan makes a final attempt to confront God and his forces.

Revelation 20:9

No battle happens (see Revelation 16:16–21; 19:19–21) because fire from heaven comes down and consumes them, just like in Sodom (Genesis 19:24; see also 2 Kings 1:10–12; Ezekiel 38:22–23; 39:6). God's enemies cannot stand against him.

Revelation 20:10

They will be tormented ... forever: Rebellion against God has eternal consequences. Some find the idea of endless punishment disturbing, but Revelation and Scripture generally convey that God will deal strictly with sin and rebellion by those who reject Christ's

saving work (see Matthew 13:42; 25:41–46; John 3:18, 36; Romans 2:7).

More than any other book in Scripture, Revelation shows that the unrepentant continue their rebellion despite the consequences (Revelation 9:20–21; 16:9–11; compare Luke 16:31). Revelation also highlights that God is just and deals with sin as it deserves.

Revelation 20:11–15

This segment describes a court hearing where the dead are judged based on their actions. God responds to ongoing rebellion with eternal punishment.

Revelation 20:12

- books were opened: See Psalm 56:8; Daniel 7:10.
- The Book of Life contains the names of faithful people who have experienced God's saving power (Malachi 3:16; see Revelation 3:5; 13:8; 17:8; 20:15). They are likely the same ones who experience the first resurrection (Revelation 20:5–6).
- the dead were judged: The works of both the redeemed and the unredeemed will be judged (see Revelation 22:12; Matthew 16:27; 25:31–46).

Revelation 20:13

Hades: See study note on Revelation 6:7–8.

Revelation 20:14

- The phrase Death and Hades refers to the reality of death, which is the last enemy God will destroy (see Revelation 21:4; 1 Corinthians 15:26).
- The lake of fire represents the terrible end for God's enemies who will not experience the first resurrection (see Revelation 20:5–6; compare Matthew 25:41; Luke 16:24; Jude 1:7).

Revelation 21:1

- The vision describes God's creation of a new heaven and earth (compare Genesis 1:1 with Isaiah 65:17; 66:22). The old creation has vanished because it was subject to decay (see Romans 8:20–21; 2 Peter 3:7, 10).
- the sea was no more: The sea symbolized chaos or the abyss (see study note on Revelation 9:1–12) and was sometimes depicted as a roaring monster (see Psalms 46:3; 74:14; see also Job 3:8; 41:1–34; Luke 21:25). The new creation will be free from all such evil.

Revelation 21:1–22.9

The final scenes of the new heaven and earth show a new community and home for God's people, created and given by God. These scenes uplift persecuted Christians. John shares his main vision (Revelation 21:1–8) and expands on it in two parts:

1. In Revelation 21:9–27, he describes the new Jerusalem as a place of holy perfection;
2. in Revelation 22:1–5, he portrays the new Jerusalem as the ultimate garden of Eden, which Adam and Eve could have experienced if they had not sinned.

Revelation 21:2

- coming down ... from God: The new creation is a gift from God. At first, God created everything good. In the end, God will create a new, perfect world.
- This image of Jerusalem as a beautiful bride (see Isaiah 61:10) contrasts sharply with the vision of Babylon (or Rome) as the prostitute (Revelation 17:4–5; 18:2–3; see study note on Revelation 21:9–22:9).

Revelation 21:3

The dwelling place of God is with man: The hopes of the Old and New Testaments are fully realized. Since humanity sinned (Genesis 3), separation from God has been humanity's biggest problem (Genesis 3:23). God has called his people to him through the prophets, Jesus his Son, and the Spirit's presence (see Genesis 17:8; Exodus 29:45–46; Psalms 46:4–5; 95:7; Jeremiah 7:23; 31:33; Ezekiel 34:14; 37:27; Zechariah 8:8; John 14:2–3; 17:24). In the new heaven and earth, God's people will finally enjoy ultimate and everlasting fellowship with God.

Revelation 21:4

no more death or mourning or crying or pain: See Isaiah 25:8; 1 Corinthians 15:54. God's people will experience the complete healing and salvation that Christ brings (see 2 Corinthians 5:17; Galatians 6:15).

Revelation 21:6

- God repeats Jesus's final words from the cross, It is done! (John 19:30; see also Revelation 16:17), linking Christ's death to the promise of eternal life.
- I am the Alpha and the Omega: Using the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet, John shows God as the source of all reality and truth. God existed from the Beginning (see Genesis 1:1; see also John 1:1–2) and is also the End (see Revelation 1:8; 22:13).
- Since Christ is supreme and controls everything (see Romans 9:5; 1 Corinthians 15:28; Ephesians 1:22–23; 4:5–6), he provides the water of life to all who seek it

(see study note on Revelation 7:16–17; see also Isaiah 55:1; John 4:10; 7:37–38).

Revelation 21:7

The one who overcomes: God's children who persevere in life will receive his blessings. Adoption is a covenant relationship. The language of adoption confirms their privileges and responsibilities (compare Genesis 17:8; 2 Samuel 7:14–16; Jeremiah 31:33; Ezekiel 34:24).

Revelation 21:8

- This list summarizes sins described in Revelation. These sins mark those not adopted by God; their fate is the fiery lake (see Romans 1:29–32; Galatians 5:19–21; 2 Timothy 3:2–5; compare Exodus 20:13–17; see also study note on Revelation 20:10).
- all liars: John saw deception as the root of sin; he describes Satan as the father of lies elsewhere (John 8:44; 1 John 2:4; see Revelation 14:5; 21:27; 22:15; compare Matthew 12:34).

Revelation 21:9–22.9

This symbolic vision of the new Jerusalem uses vivid imagery to describe the bride, the wife of the Lamb. It represents all who accept Christ's message of salvation (see Revelation 21:2; 22:17; Ephesians 5:22–32).

Revelation 21:10

- a mountain great and high: In Scripture, people often experience God on mountains (compare Ezekiel 40:2; see also Exodus 3:1; 19:10–25; Deuteronomy 34:1–4; 1 Kings 18:20–40; 19:8–18; Matthew 5:1; 15:29; 17:1; 24:3; 28:16).
- the holy city ... coming down out of heaven from God: People cannot reach God's presence and eternal life by their own efforts. They receive it as a gift (Ephesians 2:8–9; compare 2 Corinthians 5:1).

Revelation 21:11

- Like God's true people, the city's glory reflects God's glory (compare Exodus 34:29–35; 2 Corinthians 3:7–11).
- On earth, jasper is not transparent. But in heaven, the jasper is clear like crystal. Its perfect transparency shows God's purity and integrity (see also Revelation 4:3; 21:11, 18).

Revelation 21:12–14

In this vision, the twelve tribes of Israel symbolize God's redeemed people (see Revelation 7:4–8; see also Romans 9:6–7). The twelve apostles of the Lamb form the foundation for this community of God's redeemed. Through Jesus, God has fully fulfilled his promise to bless all the families of the earth through Abraham (Genesis 12:3).

Revelation 21:15–17

measure the city: Measuring sets accepted boundaries. This contrasts with the unmeasured section of the temple (see Revelation 11:2 and Ezekiel 40:3–42:20).

Revelation 21:16

The city is a perfect cube. Each side measures 2253 kilometers (Greek 12,000 stadia). The number 12,000 symbolically represents the people of God (see "Symbolic Numbers" Theme Note).

Revelation 21:17

In the ancient world, walls were important for a city's defense, boundaries, and status. These walls, 65.8 meters thick (Greek 144 cubits), show the strength of God's redeemed people. The measurement of 144 cubits uses a multiple of 12 to symbolize God's people. A cubit was the length of a man's forearm, typically about 45.8 centimeters.

Revelation 21:18

The wall is made of jasper (see study note on Revelation 21:11; compare Revelation 4:3). The city is crafted from gold, which is not opaque like earthly gold. Instead, like God's transformed people, the heavenly gold is clear and pure.

Revelation 21:19

The twelve precious stones on the city's wall foundation remind us of the twelve stones on the high priest's breastplate. These stones represented God's people (see Exodus 28:17–20).

Revelation 21:21

In heaven, common building materials are the things we consider precious and luxurious on earth.

Revelation 21:22

I saw no temple: This seems to conflict with earlier visions (Revelation 11:19; 14:15–17). However, each vision in Revelation symbolically represents God's presence. There is no need for a temple in heaven because God is with his people.

Revelation 21:23

- The city's vitality, energy, and life come from the glory of God and the Lamb, not from institutions or physical sources of power and light. The sun and moon were part of the first creation (Genesis 1:14–19; see Isaiah 60:19–20).
- The Lamb is its lamp: Jesus is the light of the world (see John 8:12; 9:5; 12:35–36).

Revelation 21:24–25

- the nations: God's promise to Abraham comes true (Genesis 12:3; see Isaiah 2:3).
- In Revelation, the kings of the world often represent God's enemies (Revelation 6:15; 17:18; 18:3, 9). Now that these enemies are destroyed (Revelation 16:9, 11; 19:1–2, 19–21), the image is of God's glory shown in those who have repented (Revelation 14:6–7; compare 11:13) and walk with God (5:9; 15:4).
- The gates that are never closed contrast with ancient times when closed gates protected cities from enemies, especially at night. The people experience peace and security under God's rule (see Isaiah 60:11). God's enemies are gone, and fear and failure have ended (see Zechariah 14:7; John 11:8–10; 12:35–36).

Revelation 21:27

unclean: Spiritual impurity is a key concern in Revelation (see Revelation 21:8). Here, evil includes idolatry and dishonesty (see Revelation 14:5; 21:8; 22:15). Those not listed in the Book of Life cannot enter the city of God. Only those with names in the Book of Life, the pure of heart (Matthew 5:8), will see God.

Revelation 22:1

See Revelation 7:17; John 4:10–15; compare with Exodus 17:1–7; Isaiah 55:1; Ezekiel 47:1–10; Zechariah 14:8.

Revelation 22:1–2

This part of John's vision of the city shows how God provides water and food for his people (compare Exodus 16:4, 22–24; Ezekiel 47:1–12; John 4:10; 6:32–35). God first created a "garden of delight" (Eden) for Adam and Eve, but they disobeyed him and lost it (Genesis 2–3). Now, Eden is remade and joined with the heavenly city as God's wonderful gift for his faithful people.

Revelation 22:2

After humans sinned, they lost access to the tree of life (see Genesis 3:22–24), but now it is freely available. The tree stands on each side of the river (compare Ezekiel 47:12), showing there is no wrong side of the river in heaven. The tree produces fresh fruit every month, demonstrating God's constant provision.

Revelation 22:3

- No longer ... any curse: Since the first sin (Genesis 3:14–19), humanity has faced a curse due to their rebellion against God (see 1 Corinthians 16:22). Now, rebellion, sin, and the curse are gone forever.
- His servants will worship him: Revelation shows examples of true worship (see Revelation 4–5; 7:9–17).

Revelation 22:4

The fear of death and seeing God will disappear (see Genesis 16:13; 32:30; Judges 6:22; Isaiah 6:5). God's people will carry his name and joyfully see his face (see Matthew 5:8; 2 Corinthians 3:18; 1 John 3:2–3).

Revelation 22:5

They will rule with God forever (see Revelation 20:4; see also 5:10) in his bright light that removes night and the need for lamps (see Isaiah 60:19–20).

Revelation 22:6

Everything John records in Revelation is trustworthy and true because God, who has all authority (compare Matthew 28:18), sent the messenger. However, these visions are not easy to understand.

Revelation 22:6–21

This epilogue to Revelation includes words from an angel (Revelation 22:6, 8–11) and Christ (22:7, 12–19). It ends with a plea for Christ's return (Revelation 22:20) and a final blessing (22:21). The epilogue connects directly with the book's introduction (Revelation 1:1–11). It highlights key themes such as:

- encouraging faithful perseverance,
- warning those who do evil things,
- affirming the truth of the prophetic message, and
- restating the nearness of Christ's return.

Revelation 22:7

Blessed: The sixth blessing in Revelation (see Revelation 1:3; 14:13; 16:15; 19:9; 20:6; 22:14) is for those who obey. Obedience is essential for God's blessing.

Revelation 22:8–9

The warning against false worship (see Revelation 19:10) is repeated when John falls at the angel's feet again. Only God deserves our worship (compare John the Baptist's relationship to Jesus; John 1:6–8, 26–27; 3:27–35).

Revelation 22:10

Do not seal up: The angel expands John's initial instruction to Write on a scroll (Revelation 1:11) and warns against limiting its communication. Although some things are sealed, God does not reveal everything (compare Revelation 10:4). What has been written must be shared so people understand the message's seriousness and that the time is near (see Revelation 1:1, 3; 22:6–7; compare Daniel 12:4).

Revelation 22:11

People who refuse to accept God's forgiveness will remain wicked (see Revelation 16:9). John reminds good people to keep their integrity. This verse warns wrongdoers and urges the righteous to understand the importance of Christ's return for their commitments and actions.

Revelation 22:12

Christ is coming soon to repay everyone, not just based on their faith, but according to their actions (see Revelation 2:23; 11:18; 14:13; 20:12–13; see also Proverbs 24:12; Matthew 16:27; 2 Corinthians 5:10). Not every statement of belief is sincere (John 2:23–25); true faith shows through actions (James 2:14–26). We are saved by God's grace and power in Christ. Our actions do not save us, but they show the seriousness of our confession and provide a fair basis for our final reward or punishment.

Revelation 22:14

- Blessed are those: In response to the link between actions and final outcomes (Revelation 22:12), the seventh blessing of Revelation (see also 1:3; 14:13; 16:15; 19:9; 20:6; 22:7) promises acceptance for those who wash their robes. These are people purified by trusting in Christ and following him faithfully (Revelation 3:5; 6:11; 7:9–10, 14; 19:13; Ephesians 5:26; Hebrews 10:22).
- enter the city by its gates: See study note on Revelation 21:24–25.

Revelation 22:15

- This verse lists those not allowed to enter, contrasting with those admitted in Revelation 22:14 (see 21:8, 27; 22:11). Unrepentant sinners stay outside the city. It warns that those who do not repent cannot enter the city of God (Revelation 22:14).
- The term dogs for sinners was a common Jewish label for outsiders (see Matthew 7:6; Philippians 3:2; also 2 Samuel 3:8; 2 Kings 8:13); Jews used this term for Gentiles (see Mark 7:26–28).

Revelation 22:16

- I am the Root and the Offspring of David: Jesus confirms the message of Revelation (compare John 21:24). He is the Root of David (see Revelation 5:5; Isaiah 11:10) and a descendant of David (see Ezekiel 37:23–24; Romans 1:3).
- The morning star was a title for the Messiah (see Numbers 24:17; 2 Peter 1:19; compare Luke 1:78–79).

Revelation 22:17

- Come is a repeated invitation and a confession (see Revelation 22:20).
- the bride: The Lamb's wife (see Revelation 21:9), represents the church, the people of God.
- The thirsty can drink freely from God's provision (see Revelation 21:6; 22:1; Psalm 42:1; Isaiah 55:1; John 4:10–14).

Revelation 22:18–19

- I testify: John swears to protect the integrity of the Book of Revelation. He curses anyone who changes the book's content or message (compare Deuteronomy 4:2; 12:32). This curse contrasts with the blessing for those who read aloud, listen to, and follow the prophecy (Revelation 1:3). When Revelation was written, scribes sometimes changed books to fit their views. Early Christians quickly developed ways to verify messages and messengers (see John 21:24; 1 Corinthians 16:21; Galatians 6:11; Colossians 4:18; 2 Thessalonians 3:17; 1 John 4:1–3).
- Since the early church, the New Testament's scope and content have defined Christian teachings. However, some still try to change Scripture by adding works they consider equal to the Bible or by claiming parts of the Bible are unreliable. The true church has rejected and will continue to reject these attempts to change the canon, viewing them as human or even demonic efforts to alter the foundation of the Christian faith.

Revelation 22:20

- I am coming soon: See Revelation 3:11.
- Come, Lord Jesus!: Paul expressed the same wish (1 Corinthians 16:22; see also Philippians 4:5).

Revelation 22:21

- Revelation ends with a blessing similar to those in Paul's letters (for example, Romans 15:33; 1 Corinthians 16:23–24).
- The final sentence fittingly calls upon the grace of the Lord Jesus, which is the foundation of our forgiveness and the basis of our eternal hope.